# Her Liege

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# Her Liege

by n7punk

Summary

Catra chafes under the title of Princess sometimes, truly the Queen of the Waste and only held back from that title by the treaty that wrote every nation as a vassal state of Bright Moon, but Queen Angella did soothe the sting by assigning Catra her most precious knight as a bodyguard to help enforce peace in the lawless desert.
Adora may find the inhospitality of the Waste hard to manage as a human without the insultation of fur or scales to keep the hot rays of the sun away from her skin, but she's honored to serve the princess that might be the most distinguished general after herself. To serve a princess she loves is even better, though her quiet longing does introduce challenges at times. She has overcome war – she can shoulder the weight of love.
(Or, a Princess Catra/Knight Adora AU set in a medieval-inspired Etheria)

Notes

Silver fox Catra agenda 🗣️🗣️!!!! but they're still in their 30s because they need to be stupid, even I can't keep them pining into their 40s. They only lasted this long because they only met a few years ago lol. The war haggard her enough to make her prematurely sexy 😼
This fic is part of the Thank You She-ra event to celebrate She-ra before it leaves Netflix, written for the week three prompt: Season 3. Though this is obviously set in an alternative universe, it's also set in the Crimson Waste, which they visit for the first time in season three, so this is what you're getting XD
**Read the tags**!! Inherent power imbalances (in both directions), the gruesome nature of medieval war, etc.

# Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra's mask is custom made for her. It's perfectly molded to rest on her face, only small combs on the edge of her hairline needed to hold it in place for when she leans forward. She was raised with a series of masks, some less fitted or needing more help to stay in place than others as she grew, all to make her feel the most natural when the symbol of her power is resting on her face. It's almost uncomfortable when it's off

All that is to say, Catra's migraine cannot possibly be coming from her crown right now and thus can only be sourced from the knight across from her, blathering on. Duncan is a delegate from Bright Moon. Catra has to listen to him. Technically every country, including her own, is a vassal state of Bright Moon. The Crimson Waste is still the most autonomous. They import food but could go without the variety brought in even if it would probably lead to riots. Fabric is more necessary, hard to grow any comfortable fibers in the waste, but they still grow most of their non-clothing textiles and they can switch the tapestry tailors to clothes if they were desperate for it.

In turn, *everyone* needs them for their mines. They and the Fright Zone are always in competition for the best rates, but rumors are the Fright Zone is becoming overmined and it's affecting their land's health, so Catra is posed well for any negotiations with her queen's cabinet.

This just isn't negotiations. She's not clear why he's even here except to test her patience. He doesn't seem to be spying on her or have secret motivations. Queen Angella isn't very conniving because she doesn't have to be. Ever since the arrangement that put all the "princesses" in place, there has been relative peace between the kingdoms. Catra still chafes under the title of princess sometimes, denied the title of queen of her people and no less deserving of it than Angella, who doesn't actually have anything to do with the ruling of her vassal countries, but if her moms stomached it for the sake of peace, so can she. The most recent upheaval came from invaders across the sea, and Catra supposes Bright Moon earned their keep then coordinating the opposing effort to drive them off with all the armies in the land and sea.

Catra's eyes slide to the woman standing behind the blathering idiot's shoulder, a few feet back, posed with the tip of her sword resting on the stone floor and her hands crossed over the hilt. Either he's here for a purposeless social visit, or he's here for her.

"I'm sure you're unused to the schedule of the desert, Sir Duncan, but sundown is falling and thus lunch is being prepared. We should break so you can make any requests you may have of the kitchen to accommodate a human palate and we can refresh. I have matters of state I must attend to as well. Is there anything else you require of me before we reconvene?" Catra asks when Duncan pauses for air. He blinks at her, surprised, and Catra sees the way his eyes flick to the right, in Adora's direction, though from where he's seated she must only be a glint of gold and white in the corner of his eye.

“I appreciate the consideration. I will do my best to adjust during my short visit to not inconvenience you. I do bring some correspondences for Princess Adora,” Duncan says. Adora’s head jerks up from where she was keeping it in a solemn bow – she was looking proper while zoning out from boredom and Catra knows it, despite how, no matter what, Catra is certain she was still alert. Catra makes eye contact with her bodyguard over Duncan’s shoulder.

“Gather what you need from your caravan and she will join us for lunch,” Catra says as if she ever breathes without Adora in the room. Adora’s jaw shifts slightly.

She’s pouting, because that means she’ll be sitting at the table and people will actually be looking at her.

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Adora hasn’t worn her full ceremonial armor for a while. She only does it when dignitaries are visiting, and Duncan is an honored part of the guard that trained her so she wanted to impress him until she met him. Now she remembers why she likes the Waste’s way of doing things better than Bright Moon.

She misses Bright Moon *a lot*, but the Waste’s culture suits her well. Magicats are to the point, practical, and don’t posture like most nobles. Even the way they structure their sentences is more direct. It’s why she doesn’t wear her ceremonial armor daily anymore, preferring the treated leather most wear beneath the heat of the Waste, though at times she misses the comforting weight of metal and even likes when another tribe comes to visit and she has to don her regalia. It heats far too fast to actually wear to battle in the desert, but she trained in it for a long time and it’s familiar.

There’s a reason their day starts after the sun has passed its highest point and runs well into the dark.

“Do you know him?” Catra asks, brisk, as they make their way down the sandstone halls of the magicat palace, polished to a perfect shine. It’s a sign of their wealth, their control, that they can keep it free of scuffs from the rough sand streams that kick up through the Waste.

“No. I graduated from his guard ten years ago,” Adora reminds, following close behind. She’s sure the clink of her armor is grating on Catra’s hearing. Catra draws to an abrupt halt by one of the many narrow windows set into the right side of the hallway and turns, taking two steps to place her hands on the windowsill and leaning out the opening, taking a few deep breaths to center herself. Adora, because it’s her job, sweeps her eyes out the window to scan for threats.

The palace courtyard is empty. No assassin is lurking on the roofs of the many low buildings that make up the palace and its surrounding town tucked against a cliff edge, the sands gently rolling in the distance as the winds tumble the grains on the surface. Architecture varies in

the Waste by settlement and by tribe, but the magicats use clean lines with simple carvings, polished finishes, and paint to create what they consider elegant architecture. They have an excessive amount of windows that Adora must always sweep, because Catra is a big target and there's often one in the room without any glass in it from the sand specks on the wind eventually scratching it enough to buckle.

There are many tribes in the Waste, and they never agree on who should be the ruling one, but Catra has brought the Waste to her heel when tribes or gangs tried to revolt twice now and her mothers brought the magicats back to the center of the culture after a few decades of constant turmoil between the tribes. There are still those who are eager to buck her rule despite how a stable central government has benefitted them all. No one is really arguing it doesn't – they just want to be the ones in charge of it.

Catra proved during the war why that shouldn't be the case.

"Do you find him as grating as me?" Catra sighs, shoulders falling as she expels the tension from her body and lets it be taken on the desert breeze.

"You're not nearly as annoying as him," Adora says, and she smirks when Catra turns to hit her arm and then growls upon being confronted with the shining white and gold of her armor. She turns away with a scoff as Adora snickers. "I did lose some of my sensitization to afternoons like this," Adora admits. Catra chuffs.

"Well, you're a victim along with me this evening. Is the correspondence anything I need to be aware of?" Catra asks. Adora catches herself glancing down to her left gauntlet and the crest embellished there.

"No, it's probably just Glimmer and Bow. Not unless they want me to attend Angel's birthday. I don't think it's a milestone this year," Adora says, and then Catra groans.

"I forgot about that," she admits, wrinkling her nose, and Adora knows she means *the human child* rather than just his age.

"I haven't been in a year. They'll want me to visit soon," Adora reminds, because it needs to be said, and she does miss her friends. She can't pretend not to be glad that the years she's apart from them are the same as the years they have a small child, though. Angel is cute, but he also stresses her out. Her hands are meant to hold a sword, not support a head she has to rotate so it maintains the perfect shape while the skull is still soft. She highly doubts anyone rotated her head as a child and she turned out fine.

She's sure Catra would have a comment about that if she said it out loud, so she doesn't. Angel is well passed that age but no less anxiety-inducing, anyway.

"Wait for the summer, I'll be glad for a break from the Waste then – and Lashor will be made too tame by the heat to try to overthrow me again," Catra says. Adora's lips twitch.

"I'll make sure to include it in my letter back," she promises. They could line that up with Glimmer's summer gala that they missed last year and that would probably make Glimmer happy enough to accept the delay. Catra sighs and turns away from the window.

“Let’s find somewhere to sprawl until lunch is ready and we have to be formal again,” she decides. Adora gives a small cough. “Oh, you *knew* I was lying about matters of state, don’t start,” Catra dismisses her with a wave of her hand. Adora’s lips twitch, but she follows after her princess.

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Adora is a princess in title only, but privately Catra thinks she’s better at playing nice with Bright Moon elite than Catra is. Catra didn’t earn Adora’s placement in her court with niceties – she earned it by being the uniting force in the Waste that finally got Bright Moon the men and military that they needed to win the war. Adora was given to her both to help her enforce compliance within her own kingdom and as a symbol of honor afterwards. As peace stretches, the tribes who saw the sense in uniting under a common banner grow restless and more eager for war with each other without a general directing them to the front lines.

Adora’s purpose is as ceremonial as it is practical, and Catra can defend herself in practice. Adora can earn *her* keep by knowing the right things to say at the right times to keep Duncan blathering on with minimal effort or input from either of them so they can actually eat their lunch. Duncan is clearly tiring severely and their day is only half-started, but then again Duncan is tiring *Catra* with his talking, so maybe it is an effect he has even on himself.

“It is good to see you still thriving in the Waste, Adora. The Princess sends her regards and asks after you,” Duncan finally says after what feels like an hour. Catra chuffs into her next bite of food, earning a quick glance from Duncan, but his brow is furrowed and he doesn’t seem sure he heard anything of note at all.

“I’ll prepare a letter for her so she can hear from me herself. I do dearly miss her and a temperate afternoon, but there is still fighting to be done in the Waste, and the same cannot be said for Bright Moon,” Adora responds. Catra feels weirdly proud. She shouldn’t be pleased that her kingdom is one of the few experiencing any unrest, but her might as both a unifier and a warrior is strongly displayed by it. It’s cultural for them to vie for the position of the strongest tribe and the right to rule the Waste – it’s her own prowess that places that right at her feet.

“You are Bright Moon’s strongest warrior and there isn’t anywhere we would rather have you than where you can exercise your sword, but you are still missed,” Duncan assures Adora as Catra suppresses a scowl. Adora is not Bright Moon’s at the moment, but Catra supposes that technically she – and thus Adora and the rest of her kingdom – is Bright Moon’s on a legal level.

The Waste has never cared much for legalities.

“I can’t deny myself the thrill of a fight,” Adora replies, and it’s nice that she’s at least reinforcing that she prefers being here. Catra doesn’t know how long that will last, or how

long Adora will be appointed as her bodyguard, but she does know she will struggle to ever bring another to her side. She doesn't want anyone to follow her as doggedly as Adora does.

She makes Catra feel like she is actually her queen.

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Adora is not the ruler of a country like Princess Catra, or in line to do so like Princess Glimmer. She's the leader – the ruler – of the unified army when it is standing. Though there is a national peacetime now, the ceremonial title remains with her in case she is needed again. Perhaps new ships could sail from across the sea to finish what the Horde started, and it's not like she isn't still fighting for peace, though the conflicts within the Waste never leave it. Angella wouldn't strip her of the title she spent her entire life earning.

Adora is not a princess like Catra is a princess, *a queen*, but because of her title, and because of her position as Catra's bodyguard, she does live in the royal suite. After a long day with Duncan, wishing Glimmer came herself but understanding why she was too busy to, she settles in for the hardest part of her day. After she saw Catra's ears twitch, struggling not to pin back from irritation during her first boring meeting with Duncan, she knew it would be one of these days. They're the days that make her believe in divine mercy, punishment, and *comedy*.

She listens to Catra moan on the other side of the wall, sometimes panting *a*s that sound like they could be the start of Adora's name as she does so. Adora's hands fists the sheets. She knows she's delusional in what she thinks she's hearing, but she goes back and forth on if Catra knows that she can hear her. It's quiet enough that Adora wouldn't really be able to hear it if it ever happened while she was up and moving around, and she only ever hears her doing it after Adora has gone to bed and could reasonably be asleep to miss it entirely. There aren't a lot of humans in the Waste and it's possible Catra could be underestimating her hearing.

The other possibility is that Catra is acting as divine punishment or temptation herself and Adora doesn't know which is worse. From the moment she met Catra during a war council meeting, she was stunned by her beauty, and impressed even more when she learned of her capabilities. It progressed to full lust the first time she saw Catra *exercise* those capabilities. It was never appropriate for her to have. Adora was raised at the feet of royalty to be their guard, however close her friendship with Glimmer became, and Catra was raised to rule through both birthright and a skillful fist. She's the queen of her people and Adora is her servant – *happy* to serve.

Too happy. The occasional moans that make it through the thick wall test every resolve she has. She didn't get this far without self-restraint, but her body tells her she can break now and no one would ever know. Even if she heard Catra call her name plain as day she would never mention it to her. It isn't appropriate for someone of her station to make an advance, and

she's sure Catra is just making… normal moaning sounds and not what Adora wants them to be, but her body can convince her of a lot when it comes to the woman she craves.

Adora is far from isolated in the palace. She was once betrothed in her youth and continues to receive proposals ever since she earned her title in the war, and being one of the few humans here has intrigued nearly as many as it has turned away. If she wanted to seek someone, she could. She could satisfy her lust in the hours where Catra does not need her and return to her service with this desire exercised from her mind. She could. Maybe.

She doesn't want to. She closes her eyes and reaches for her laces. Unlike Catra, she has to be *silent*, because if Catra doesn't know she can hear her, she'll figure it out the moment she realizes that Adora joined her.

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One thing Catra doesn't know she could ever do again without Adora is rise on time. She's woken by a soft hand on her shoulder. She makes a noise she doesn't care to categorize because she knows what category *Adora* would place it in and Adora reaches up, brushing Catra's hair that is starting to streak with grey from her face, letting in more light from the narrow window slits that Adora has pulled the curtains back from like always.

"Breakfast is here," Adora says, her voice warm and, yep, amused. Catra chirps at her and promptly rolls over. "Princess," Adora prompts, voice quivering with laughter. Gentle appeals failed, Catra growls. "You're not threatening to me in your nightshift," Adora informs her and that, finally, gets Catra to open her eyes so she can turn her head and glare at Adora, growling harder. Adora's lips twitch. Catra halfheartedly tries to swipe at her, and Adora steps back easily. She's back in time to catch Catra's arm and drag her into a sitting position before it can fall. Catra reluctantly lets herself be guided out of bed. Adora turns her head and doesn't look at her once Catra is standing. Her nightshift is a lightweight fabric, imported from Bright Moon. It's transparent enough to see her stripes and the gray flecks that have extended to her coat. Catra reaches up and pushes her hair out of her face.

"Begin breakfast. I'll join you shortly. Any word on Duncan?" Catra mumbles, rubbing at her cheek to help herself wake up. Adora is still vaguely looking out the window. She's dressed in plain clothes without any armor at all, so she's not ready to go out for the day yet and Catra can't use which set of armor she has chosen as a clue.

"I believe he's on your evening docket after lunch and then he'll be leaving to travel to the Valley of the Lost next. He'll be back in a week to stay shortly before returning to Bright Moon," Adora informs her. Catra nods.

"Plenty of time to read and write your letters," she agrees. Adora is by her side most times, but she does have some free time. If she can't find it, over the course of the next week Catra set time aside to do nothing herself so Adora can do whatever she likes during it. She tries to do that for Adora when she can. Adora takes care of her, and she takes care of her knight.

“I read them last night. I can probably convince Glimmer that the summer is acceptable,” Adora jokes, gently, but she steps away, towards the door. Catra scowls.

“Tell her that’s for me to decide and I’m hoarding you,” she says, and Adora laughs. Catra immediately wants to double down despite how it was supposed to be a joke to let off steam. It was too real. Adora belongs to *her*. She was given to her and Catra tries to ignore the knowledge that Adora is the Knight-Princess of Bright Moon and could be taken away, because she’s *her* bodyguard.

On a night after she soothed herself with thoughts of *Adora* soothing her, she doesn’t like to remember that. She has visited Bright Moon with Adora at her side twice now, and every time it’s jarringly different from their relationship in the Waste, Catra no longer her ultimate superior and Angella not afraid to give Adora her own orders so she has duties other than just what Catra gives her. She likes when Adora’s life revolves around her.

She likes it too much. It’s why she begrudgingly facilitates these times. She can’t keep Adora forever. Barring Angella, Adora might one day request to return to Bright Moon. It was her home for over thirty years, after all. That she has adapted to the Waste so well in just a few years is impressive, but Catra doubts she wants to be here forever. She has never asked, because she doesn’t want to know the answer. She’ll live in her little delusion where she and Adora share a house by choice rather than circumstance for as long as Adora will let her. She is not inclined to deny Adora the things she wants and sour their relationship.

“Careful, she’ll storm the place,” Adora says, still chuckling, and Catra watches her go with an ache in her chest.

She was so isolated before Adora came. Raised as the sole heir, the most valuable individual in the Waste dead or alive to get at her moms, she was beyond *approach*. She needed to be kept close. Magicats are highly social and she missed many milestones because it wasn’t safe for her to have them. The people who surrounded her were staff – trusted staff, but not *friends*, not people her age. As she got older, those scales balanced, but she still never grew close with anyone the way that she craved, not until Adora. The only person she ever shared a bed with was her mothers, curling up at their feet far past her kitten years because she was lonely and felt safe there.

She turns away from the door and approaches the closet.

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Adora almost knocks over her cup when Catra walks into the dining room at the front of the royal suite. Catra definitely notices, tail flicking stiffly, and Adora hurries to try to look busy, *normal*, wracking her brain for nice subjects to distract Catra over breakfast. She thought everything was fine. She was the normal level of reluctant when Adora went to wake her. She didn’t think she was rousing her from a nightmare, but not all bad dreams involve screaming or adrenaline.

Sometimes they're quiet, sad. Sometimes they lead you to put on your mothers claws in silence.

The necklace is heavy, the base of each claw fused with gold and affixed to the chain in two layers, one chain for each of her mothers. Adora finds it morbid to wear the nails of your dead, but some humans wear the ashes of their family in lockets. There's no difference, really, except that the claws still look as they did on her mothers' hands before they were pried off after their death, a visible piece of what they were rather than an amorphous grey essence. To the magicats, that honors their memory more. To Adora, it's grosser, and sadder, because Felina's chain is almost a choker on Catra, only one hand left to preserve when they found her after the battle she still ultimately secured victory in.

It doesn't matter how she feels about the practice in theory; it matters that it means Catra isn't in a good headspace. Adora is pretty sure she's the only who knows that, because it isn't always true. Sometimes Catra chooses it for strategic reasons – to display her birthright, to show her pragmatism, to show the lineage and values she was raised with – and sometimes she does it to honor them. Birthdays, anniversaries, days she just wants people to remember who her mothers were. Adora can tell when she isn't doing it for those reasons, so she knows there are times when it's for *bad* reasons.

It's no anniversary. Duncan will be mildly disturbed by the necklace, but Catra has no reason to threaten or upset him. There is no one else in the palace who hasn't seen Catra wearing it a half dozen times before.

Maybe Adora should pretend it's normal. Maybe she shouldn't acknowledge it and try to distract her. That's usually what she does. But Catra seemed fine just twenty minutes ago.

As Catra sits in her chair, Adora stands. Catra looks up, clearly surprised by Adora breaking protocol. She watches with confusion as Adora steps behind her, her tail twitching and half-turning to follow her.

"You know, Glimmer's letter reminded me of this Bright Moon tradition I haven't gotten to do in a while," Adora says. Catra's tail stills and she tilts her head straight back, looking up at Adora with an adorable furrow in her brow. Catra somehow still manages to look like a kitten sometimes despite being well into her thirties. Her greying started early, hitting her almost immediately after the war like all the stress and grief was catching up with her.

It's fine, it looks really good on her. Frankly, Adora doesn't know how she hasn't gotten more proposals, but magicat culture favors bonding over arranged marriages like Bright Moon. The Waste in general lacks when it comes to political marriages. You don't negotiate for what you want – you take it.

"What are you talking ab-" Catra starts to ask, cutting off with a sharp squeak when Adora hugs her from behind and squeezes her tight, awkwardly bent but resting her forehead against Catra's mane, making herself as comfortable as she can as she hugs her.

"Okay, your point is made," Catra complains, but she doesn't try to wiggle free, and her chest is buzzing a little.

“What’s my point?” Adora quizzes her. Catra makes an adorable little disgruntled noise in the back of her throat. Adora resists the urge to call her cute. Catra cannot *comprehend* how often Adora has to do that, but she doesn’t want to insult her. Beyond the thirty thing, she’s also her queen. And her boss.

Catra *humphs* and suddenly she’s a kitten again. Adora smiles to herself. She squeezes Catra, raising her up off the bench. Catra kicks her feet and it feels petulant, but she’s not struggling and definitely capable of flipping Adora over the table so Adora just stands her up and Catra turns, grumbling, into her embrace and hugs her back, tucking her face into Adora’s shirt collar. Oh, that’s nice. Adora wraps her arms around Catra’s waist and holds her close.

“You’re not alone,” Adora whispers into her hair. Catra’s breath hitches.

“I have things I need to do today, Adora,” Catra tells her, weakly, barely a joke. Adora *barely* manages a chuckle, one hand reaching up to pet over Catra’s hair. She’s not taking that to heart. Catra was clearly emotional before she left her room or she wouldn’t have dressed like this. If she’s going to cry, it’s something she needs to do.

“And I’ll be there for them,” Adora whispers back.

Catra’s shoulders tremble slightly. Adora just holds her. For several long minutes, that’s all they do, standing there with Catra in her arms. Eventually, Catra draws in a shuddering breath.

“We can go to Bright Moon in the summer,” she manages. Adora glances down, surprised.

“You want more of these fancy hugs?” Adora teases and Catra lets out a soft *ha*, a little caught between a sob and a laugh, and hugs Adora back.

“I have enough Bright Moon right here,” she promises and Adora’s chest feels… wet. Catra clears her throat. It also sounds like there’s something wet there. “Come on, breakfast is getting cold,” Catra nudges her, finally pulling back. Adora lets her sit back in her chair, walking back to sit in her own.

It’s a breakfast like every other where she wears the necklace after that – enough discussion flowing to keep Catra distracted and her spirits up. A hug can’t solve anything. It can’t solve most things.

When Adora walks out of her room after putting her armor on for the day, Catra is dressed in her full ceremonial robe for the day, and she isn’t wearing the necklace anymore.

Chapter End Notes

This AU doesn’t have a story btw so don’t expect one. We’re running on pure vibes and lust here. I’m not gonna do fic notes either so you’re gonna get long author notes here and there lol

-Bright Moon lowkey talks fake-fantasy style and magicats talk a lot more normal so there's a kind of blend going on here between those factors and additional formality.
-This is set in my own lil historical Etheria without magic but I am using it to explain how I think the Princess system in canon works (on a surface level since there aren't any runestones, etc in this AU)
-The central Bright Moon queen/vassal princesses arrangement has been in place for a few hundred years, but the Crimson Waste (and the Fright Zone once) has fallen in and out of the arrangement a few times, and it has been allowed because it was due to internal civil unrest that Bright Moon didn't want to back a particular candidate for and not because they attacked other nations. Whenever the political situation restabilized, they reestablished their treaties formally and they were also dealing with each other during it anyway.
-The tribes of the Waste all have their own nobility/royalty that takes over whenever their tribe becomes the central power historically. The lizardfolk, etc, still have their own nobility who would take the title of King/Queen of the Waste if the magicats lost hold of their position, but for now the title rests with Catra and the magicats. Since the title is older than the vassal arrangement and outside of what the other nations are doing, kings have been a possibility before and that title is why Catra is sometimes informally referred to as a queen even though it isn't proper. Under the Bright Moon arrangement only women can rule and their partners are Princess-Consorts and Prince-Consorts rather than kings, queens, etc.
-In the Waste, tight underlayers (bodysuits, pants, shirts, etc) covered by looser top clothing (jackets, parkas, robes, etc) to protect from the elements and keep the sun's rays from hitting the fabric that touching your skin directly are the traditional wear, so at all times Catra is basically wearing a bodysuit and covering it with additional layers. Robes may be long but still are not dresses lol, Catra only wears a "dress" to sleep and that's her nightshift.

# Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

Content Warning: Sparring in this chapters gets REALLY intense

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra has bent the more rebellious tribes to her will, but some credit must be given to Adora's presence, because having the Knight-Princess of Bright Moon facing you down is intimidating not just for her reputation, but because it makes it clear Queen Angella favors Catra, and she might not stand by if someone did try to overthrow her.

Having worked closely with her in the war, Catra thinks she wouldn't have enough spine to step in, but it's an effective deterrent to those interested in ruling. Not everyone wants to be Princess, however. Besides not being eligible for the title, Tung Lashor wants to break the law, not write it. Catra does still have to deal with the criminal gangs hidden in the sand even without any rebellions to squash.

"Is this what my mercy earns me?" Catra complains to no one in particular. She sees Adora's lips twitch in the corner of her eye.

"His tail has largely regrown by now," the messenger tacks onto the report. Catra narrows her eyes at him, tail twitching. She doesn't like that. She wanted her scars on him, because he's annoying. He never does anything bad enough to deserve the Dry Tower and yet constantly pops up.

She's the queen. She can decide when enough's enough. She just hasn't decided yet. She looks to her primary general.

"Have a squadron prepared and bait the group closer so I don't have to waste much time traveling," Catra orders. Clawdeen immediately bows.

"Right away. I will update you when they deploy and when they have started to drive him closer. I would expect him within a fortnight," Clawdeen agrees. Catra taps her claw on the arm of her throne, still somewhat undecided, but she nods to Clawdeen. Her instinct is to preserve life but not limbs. She can't keep being distracted from her kingdom by a flea, though. She has to show she's strong in battle when the opportunity presents itself, but she has better things to do. Defeating Lashor isn't particularly impressive.

She'll have at least a week to decide.

"Is he my only headache at the moment?" Catra requests, looking back to the messenger, who hesitates and then glances first at Clawdeen, and then at Adora. Adora clears her throat.

“None others reported thus far,” Adora says for him, because he wouldn’t really know anything that’s happening outside of his fort’s radius. Well, there’s that relief. Next month she’ll probably have to lead a tax raid since the settlements love dodging it like she doesn’t always investigate when payments don’t match the trade her spies have been reporting.

Sometimes she wonders if they truly don’t realize she has spies. If it hasn’t occurred to them, maybe that explains why she has stayed on top for so long.

She doesn’t like that thought, because it leaves her vulnerable if her enemies ever form a simple thought and use it against her.

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At this point, Adora is one of the few worthy of sparring with Catra.

That isn’t to say Catra doesn’t practice with others, because Adora is only one woman and she needs to fight those of different sizes, strengths, and styles, not to mention fighting *groups*, but the majority of the time, it’s just Adora, because the majority of the time it isn’t a true simulation of battle and just running through the paces, keeping the muscle memory they have toned and the *muscles* they need to enforce it.

The majority of the time, but not today. Today Catra seems frustrated, and Adora is shocked when mid-battle she throws aside her chain-sickle, forcing Adora to pull up short and redirect her momentum so her training sword, blunt but still dangerous, doesn’t collide with Catra as she storms to the edge of the arena. Adora is left standing there gaping, panting as she watches Catra snatch up her waterskin hanging from a training dummy at the edge of the private training yard.

“Princess?” Adora calls after her, deeply confused. Catra is breathing heavily too, but it’s a normal amount. Catra is too dedicated to take a water break *mid-swing*. Catra’s shoulders just rise and fall as she takes another drink and then lowers it, screwing the cap back on. She turns her head slightly in Adora’s direction, but she doesn’t truly look back.

“At ease,” she orders, her voice blank. Adora has already lowered her sword.

“Are you okay?” she calls after Catra, and is surprised by her tail lashing. She furrows her brow as she watches Catra’s shoulders rise and fall a few times as she slowly hangs the waterskin up again. She looks up at the walkway that surrounds the inner courtyard and Adora is immediately sweeping their surroundings as well, but there’s no one except the four guards, posted at every corner and high enough above them they’re barely visible.

Adora can’t exactly keep a watchful eye for incoming attackers when she is attacking Catra herself, so they always have guards for this, even if it’s supposed to be a private courtyard.

“Leave us and man the other side of your doors,” Catra suddenly commands, voice rising much louder so the words echo around the courtyard. Adora is no less confused than the uncertain glances that are exchanged amongst the guard and thrown her way, but she still nods to them to reinforce Catra’s order when they do look to her. One more round of glancing, and one is elected to speak.

“Yes, Princess,” is simple and followed by only a moment of hesitation to confirm she was truly talking to them before they slowly turn and depart, doors designed to keep sandstorms at bay swinging shut behind them. They are truly alone now, but the chances of an assassin climbing over the roof at this exact moment are slim, and the guards are still posted nearby. Adora isn’t sure what to do now. She’s not unfamiliar with Catra suddenly sharply demanding time alone, but though she portrays it as moodiness, Adora knows better. She gets overwhelmed, usually from sound, but she grew up with enough sheltering to be sensitive to the actions of others in multiple ways and sometimes she just needs a calm moment to recover.

This doesn’t seem like that to Adora, so she’s confused. At first, Catra would order her away for those moments too, but that has become rarer and rarer with time. She wants her here this time, but Adora doesn’t know *what* she wants.

“Catra,” Adora calls again, softer this time. Catra’s tail twitches tensely, but she holds her hand out to the side, open and waiting. Adora only really has to think about it for a moment. Cautiously, she starts forward and collects Catra’s chain-sickle, approaching her from behind and placing it in her hand. She immediately takes a step back as Catra tests it in her hand, deftly coiling the chain to bring the flail on the end of the chain closer. Adora can clearly see the side of her face now, but it’s blank, calculating.

“I want to fight,” Catra says. Adora furrows her brow.

“Why stop, then?” she asks. Catra releases a noise of frustration, sickle halting so she can tighten her fist around the grip, the wooden ball used for training slowly swinging at her side.

“Not spar, *fight*,” she growls back. Adora feels the sense of unease that has been growing morph into dread.

“What do you mean?” she asks, because maybe it isn’t as bad as it feels. Finally, Catra turns to her, body tensed in the way that betrays she’s already ready and expression tense.

“Fight, until you win,” she orders. Adora’s eyebrows climb.

“I can’t do that,” she immediately refutes. Catra narrows her eyes, threatening Adora with a growl despite the fact that has never worked on her. Catra knows it, so it’s just a sign she’s truly displeased.

“When was the last time I lost a fight, Adora?” Catra reminds.

“You just said *I* would win,” Adora points out, because that’s a hell of a slip.

“Yes! That’s the point,” Catra outbursts, sweeping her hands – and thus the chain of her flail, forcing Adora to take another precautionary step back – towards the arena. “I *don’t lose*. I grow complacent, I don’t test bleak scenarios, I don’t feel the sting of defeat and the determination to not experience it again. I know you know my fighting style well enough to serve me that,” Catra explains. Adora furrows her brow.

“Lashor is not worth this level of preparation,” she argues, because she feels uncomfortable. Catra rolls her eyes.

“This isn’t about him. It’s about what my training needs. This is an order, Liege,” Catra states. Adora blinks at her. Catra only calls her that when she wants to remind her that she serves her – usually on the rare occasions when Adora is bucking against the order.

“I don’t want to-”

“I don’t care,” Catra cuts over her, leaving Adora stunned. Catra’s eyes skate back to the arena, eying it for a moment before she looks back to Adora. “I don’t expect you to stab me, but you will do everything in your power to overpower me without permanent injury. You *will not let up* until I yield. Not when you think you’ve won, not when you think I’m injured – until I yield. I know you too well to think you’d give me more than a bruise even under this scenario, but you *must* fight like something is on the line. It is,” Catra orders. Adora presses her mouth into a thin line.

“What is on the line?” she asks. Catra leans back slightly, satisfied.

“If you lose, I’m not sure you have place in my enforcement party against Tung Lashor next week,” Catra states and Adora’s jaw drops.

“Catra-”

“I’ve given you an order. I expect the soldiers that I bring to follow them,” Catra continues, once again reminding her of her place. Adora stares at her.

Catra is riling her up on purpose because she *knows* Adora doesn’t want to fight her. She tightens her hand on her sword. Catra’s eyes dart to it for just a moment before meeting Adora’s gaze again. Maybe she looks mad. She’s mostly uncomfortable with the idea.

“I need this, Adora. It will be good training for us both,” Catra adds, voice marginally softer. Catra has no idea how much so. Making Catra *feel* like Adora is going 100% without Catra feeling even 100% of Adora’s body weight, much less her strength that could break her, is going to be a challenge.

It doesn’t seem she has a choice, but she really doesn’t want to hurt her. She’s scared.

--

Catra has made many concessions, and Adora is still pulling her punches. She let Adora take the time to exchange her usual training sword, metal to be the appropriate weight but dull enough it could only cut unspun wool, for a wooden alternative that couldn't even be claimed to have edges. She let them delay to put on their full armor, though that was a good idea on Adora's part, more realistic and thus more effective to match how a real battle would go. Catra is still using her usual training chain-sickle, which has just a simple wooden ball on the end of the chain rather than the usual metal spikes, and a dulled blade on the handle that could still destroy the wool fibers but not much else.

When Adora's weapon can't do more than bruise, when Catra is wearing armor that cushions even that, why does she still hold back? Catra *knows* Adora can defeat her. She also knows that she can defeat Adora, but not in this context. She doesn't think that's a secret and she has made it clear what she wants Adora to do here, so she shouldn't be worried about disrespecting her queen by besting her.

"Come *on*, Adora," Catra snarls, when Adora intercepts the swing of her sickle by catching it with the blade of her sword and shoving Catra off, but she *knows* that's not what she would do in a battle. Instead she would use the hook of the sickle to drag Catra in so she could destroy her. Adora scowls as she takes a few steps back, both of them circling each other. Catra is very good with her chain, but Adora is also familiar with how she uses it. She can dodge it when Catra goes to wrap it around her leg and yank her off her feet to then eviscerate with her sickle and claws. Adora is far slower than Catra in battle, but her chain isn't as effective without the spikes on the flail at the end to help it latch on.

"I don't know what you expect while keeping your ribs intact," Adora grits through her teeth, and then she charges. It's not even a good charge. Catra dodges it so easily she chooses to go under her sword instead of around. As she passes Adora, she hooks her sickle around and digs into Adora's lower back like she's trying to push her to the ground and gut her at the same time. Catra isn't strong enough for that without knocking Adora off-balance first, but she hears a satisfying hiss of pain. What Adora doesn't seem to know is that Catra *likes* that, even if she normally doesn't like hurting her friends. Adora holding back has irritated her enough she's not worried about friendship right now. Is she belittling her on purpose, does she not care what she wants, or does she truly think it takes only a fraction of her effort to get Catra to yield?

"Like *that*. Like I'm not going to break. Or are you not better than me, Adora? Is your position at my side *useless*?" Catra taunts.

Adora doesn't whip around, but Catra *sees* the shift in her body, sees the moment when this goes from something she doesn't want to do to something she needs to prove.

Well, good to know where her weak spot is.

--

Catra is fast.

Speed isn't everything. Her weapon works really well in the open space of the desert, but in the training yard it's easier to force her to dodge into a corner where she doesn't have the room to properly swing her chain, and without the momentum behind it or the spikes on the end, it becomes ineffective. Hand-to-hand, Catra is still impressive, but she doesn't have the strength to pull Adora's sword out of her hand with the sickle, at least not with Adora knowing exactly how she would do it, and it's not a good weapon against Adora's sword she has spent thirty years honing her skills with.

Despite all of Catra's taunting, she's holding back too, and it's only when Adora nearly has her against a wall does she try to claw, and even then it seems to be more for the element of surprise than anything. Adora lets Catra think she's slipping under her arm, and she almost *manages* to do it, but then Adora just barely has time to close her fist around Catra's tail and yank her back, earning a small, undignified yowl as Catra collapses face-first in the dirt. Adora spins to set on her immediately, but Catra sets on escaping just as fast.

Adora plunges her sword down just in front of Catra's shoulder to stop her from fleeing forward, but it's blunt. Its tip doesn't sink deep in the earth like she needs it to for a proper anchor, and Catra doesn't fear colliding with it. Her shoulder bashes into it hard, but her solution is just to twist to the side and try to kick away.

Adora still has her weight, and Catra doesn't seem prepared for Adora to abandon all grappling to sit on her waist, wrapping her thighs around it to slow her down and pivoting her sword with a yank to the side, pulling it free of the dirt and leveraging it against the bottom of Catra's jaw, not willing to press against her throat and potentially bash it. Catra, now on her back, keeps struggling and manages to work one hand up to claw at Adora's wrist so she can dislodge the sword.

Fuck, *fine*. Adora lets Catra pull her wrist away and then snaps her other hand up while she's distracted, wrapping it around Catra's throat.

Finally, Catra goes still, eyes wide and darting across the sky overhead as they both pant heavily. Adora almost feels like she's growling, an aggression she's not used to anymore drawn out of her, but she refuses to let go, because even though this seems to scare Catra more, it's less dangerous.

That's why it scares her. Because Adora can go further without pulling back, unlike the sword that could severely bruise her throat no matter how dull. Catra growls. Adora twitches her fingers on either side of her throat and Catra growls louder, but Adora doesn't let up the weight on her hips. She's not trying to actually affect her breathing, but she's putting just enough pressure into it to be a threat.

"Yield," she orders, the first order she has gotten to issue all afternoon. Catra hisses, struggling again-

Adora drops the sword Catra was still struggling to keep at bay and grabs her wrist instead, pinning that to the ground so she has her by the throat and wrist, Catra's other arm trapped

against her side by both Adora's knee and still being half beneath her body from how she had to twist to escape.

Catra struggles. She keeps fighting, but not like she did with a weapon in her hand. Adora can feel every muscle twitch as she is forced to exert all her strength on keeping the other woman trapped without crushing her. This isn't how she pictured Catra writhing between her thighs, she'll admit, but she can feel every one of her gasping breaths and the way her pulse jumps in her throat.

Adora has never choked anyone before, but she knows how to do it… right. If Catra knows what she's doing, she hopes she doesn't feel violated by it. Adora is trying to keep her safe even as she takes ownership of her body until, finally, Catra drops her growl to just gasp for air.

She struggles one last time, trying to buck her hips, but Adora's bodyweight has them firmly pinned, kicking her legs would do nothing, and trying to move her torso would tighten the choke.

"I yield," Catra gasps out like a curse, and Adora immediately lets go of her throat. Catra gasps like Adora really was squeezing the front of her throat and not just the sides, chest heaving, and Adora leans back, concerned gaze sweeping over her as she releases her and shifts her hips to sit back with her weight resting on her own knees instead of on Catra. Catra's eyes are suddenly wide and she looks more unsettled than she did when Adora had a sword to her throat. Adora scrambles to climb off of her, kneeling at her side instead and offering her hand with a small bow. Catra looks at it, and Adora can tell she considers not taking it.

Catra growls under her breath and reaches out, letting Adora pull her into a sitting position. They're close again, Adora's gaze darting over her, but the only thing that appears to be wrong is how heavily Catra is still breathing.

"Did I hurt you-"

"I'm fine," Catra refutes, standing sharply. Adora hurries to stand as Catra turns away, heart sinking into her stomach. She never should have agreed to this.

Catra stops in the middle of walking back to collect her chain-sickle on the ground, half-looking back without making eye contact like she did when she started this.

"Thank you. You've given me much to think about," she says, and then continues on her path, collecting her weapon and not looking at Adora once as she rewinds its chain to put it away for the day, apparently done training.

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Catra sent Adora away to check on the party that is being put together after their spar so she could bathe in peace. It took her a long time. She needed to wash not only sand but scent off of her. She needed to take the time caring for her body after having it taken from her.

Bad thought. She has already had enough to time have those thoughts today. She was telling Adora the truth when she said she needed to experience losing, she just lied about why and how scared she was of doing it. She didn't enjoy the losing part *at all*, but she got the shame of it over with, and she got the memory of Adora's thighs around her as a reward.

She might be a bad queen. A bad boss, at the very least, that's why she sent Adora *away* so they both could breathe easy again. She spent a long time brushing out her coat and mane afterwards like there could possibly be any grit left after that bath, but it was meditative and more time alone. Adora came in the apartment at some point, but she doesn't approach Catra's room until she's already changed for bed.

"Princess, your dinner is here," Adora calls and Catra rolls her eyes to herself, standing and opening the door. Adora has shed her armor, wearing just a shirt in Catra's colors – colors she can't see, but that are intended to threaten their enemies and set her family apart from other magicats – and a pair of loose pants for the night. She'll probably go to sleep in it, always ready to jump into action while Catra lounges. She's already in her night dress with just a robe thrown over it because she doesn't need to make Adora look at her nipples after that.

"Did you make sure there isn't a scorpion in it?" Catra asks with a quirk of her lips, because Adora is standing very formally. The joke works and she breaks her stance with a small snort, stepping aside so Catra can pass.

"Yes, I fought it off bravely," she assures. Catra chuckles to herself as Adora follows her to the dining room at the front of the apartment where the table is still being set. Catra sits as Adora stands at her shoulder until the servants are done, bowing to her before leaving.

"Will this be everything for the night?" Adora asks. Catra looks back over her shoulder, shooting Adora a confused look.

"Yes," she says, and then watches Adora give her short bow, the one she gives before leaving a room. Catra frowns. It's true that Adora doesn't join her for dinner *every* night, but it is the default most nights. "Adora, you know I want you to stay," Catra points out. Adora's lips quirk, but there's just enough pause before she straightens that Catra wonders if she really didn't know – if she took Catra sending her away earlier to mean she was uncomfortable with her right now.

"That would be presumptuous of me, Princess," Adora says, but she seems pleased as she goes to sit at her end of the table.

--

Catra has been a little… cold today. Adora honestly thought Catra might just want her report and then to be alone. Adora wouldn't mind taking her meal in her room, or waiting until Catra is done. She could even go to the kitchen if she preferred. She's glad Catra gave her clear instructions to stay. She doesn't want to think that she hurt her or made her uncomfortable when she was just trying to do what Catra asked her for, but she did worry that maybe Catra wasn't *really* expecting to lose and she was mad about it.

Catra gets right to business asking for a report when they sit to eat, though, and Adora updates her as they begin dinner.

"They're keeping the force small so they can pick away at him along the way and it will be less obvious than an army boxing his men in. Hopefully he will think you just underestimated him," Adora finishes to justify why she only listed six names. Catra chirps before shoving a bite in her mouth. Adora wonders, not for the first time, if she knows how cute that is. She can't, it's completely normal here and Adora is the weird one who likes all the little noises Catra makes.

"Do you think it's enough given how many men Lashor has?" Catra asks. Adora furrows her brow.

"Yes. We weighed and debated the safest arrangement," she says. Catra knows she would have considered this. It was the primary thing they debated. Catra doesn't look up from her plate.

"I've changed my mind," she says. Adora's lips part. Oh.

"On what?" Catra has completely thrown her today. At no point does she pause her meal for Adora's confusion, however, so Adora has to wait for her to finish chewing to get her answer.

"I'm sending you to deal with Lashor where he stands yourself. No herding," Catra says, and Adora's jaw drops. She stares at her.

Did that fight break her *faith*, or is this punishment? If it's punishment, is it for defeating her, or defying her at first, or… for enjoying the end of the fight?

"Myself?" Adora questions, words hollow with surprise. Catra's ear flicks in her direction.

"You can bring anyone you want. Execution is at your discretion, just put together a plan and leave within a day. I'll arrange a replacement guard tomorrow," Catra dismisses, popping another bite in her mouth. Adora watches her set her fork down and thinks she might finally look at her, but no, she's reaching for her glass instead.

"You're not handling it yourself," Adora clarifies because she *hates* thinking about the phrase 'replacement guard' and can't confront it head on. Catra sighs like this conversation is boring her as she sets her glass back down.

"These imbeciles can't always monopolize my time, they'll start to think they're important, and people could use a reminder why you're my guard. Having someone like you at my hand is as impressive as fighting them myself," Catra says, vaguely waving her hand. Adora stares

at her. Part of her will *always* pluck up at praise, but right now there are other more important things to focus on, because that's supposed to be a distraction whether Catra knows that fact or not.

"Catra, you would destroy him whether you choose to kill him or stay your hand. I'm only able to best you because I know everything about the way you fight," Adora argues. Catra huffs, gaze snapping up to narrow her eyes at her.

"I'm not *scared*. I have felt fear in battle and it was never against Lashor. We're past the age of war and I need to form new strategies to how I approach enforcement going forward, I can't always be riding off into the desert. I will when needed; Lashor is far from worthy of it. I haven't sent you on a solo mission since you were appointed here, you're well past due for it," Catra orders in the voice she usually uses inside her throne room when asserting her will over the kingdom. Adora doesn't believe that. It just doesn't feel right. Why, today, would Catra decide that Adora can take on her enforcement duties?

Why did she decide to spar today?

"Catra, why did we fight?" Adora asks, again. Catra rolls her eyes like it doesn't matter and goes back to her meal.

"I won't explain myself twice. We've never fought like that, it was clearly a constructive experience to have," Catra says.

Catra doesn't talk like this with her. Catra doesn't talk like she was raised in a throne room when they're alone. Still a palace, yes, but they're friends. She doesn't talk like she's giving orders in private often. Adora wants to ask if she did something. She knows she can't. It wouldn't get her an answer, it would make her seem immature and stupid, and it wouldn't be her place to question Catra even if she would answer. She can't shake the feeling that she's done something wrong, though.

She hangs her head and finally starts her meal. She's pretty sure Catra was mad at her earlier for not fighting her, and she thinks she scared Catra when they did fight, and then Catra wanted to be alone after. Adora questioning her now wouldn't help whatever is going on. Maybe she'll tell her in a few days. She thinks Catra eyes her out of the corner of her eye, but she tries to just get through her meal so she can leave her alone. That last thing it is a bodyguard's job to do is question their queen.

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Catra doesn't know what to say to Adora, because she told her the truth, but she's clearly worried. She seems to think Catra is upset, but that is *not* why she needed to be alone after their fight. It's not why she's sending her, either. Felina died on a raid, but that hasn't made Catra afraid of them, it has made her *aware* that she needs to carefully strategize around them. Leaving her palace unprotected is as dangerous as leaving it is for her.

Adora is giving her the silent treatment now. Catra is feeling petulant over it. Adora isn't supposed to ignore her. It's not just ignoring, though, it's *active avoidance*. Adora averts her eyes in a way Catra sees on new servants but never on her *friends*. Never on Adora. Catra can't help but remember the way Adora's face changed when Catra finally yielded, a flash of something like mild horror. She was so intense, snarling as she held her down, and then it broke and it wasn't the Knight-Princess holding her down anymore, just Adora helping her up.

Catra doesn't like being avoided. She doesn't like the way Adora won't look at her. She wants Adora's attention on her always. She doesn't know what Adora is waiting for, though.

"Princess," Catra says, and it seems to startle Adora. Her head snaps up, but for just a second her eyes dart around the room before they land on Catra, like she's looking for someone else who could feasibly be addressed *princess* in the room. As much as Adora and Catra both like to forget, Adora does still hold the title, just not the way that Catra does. When Adora's eyes land on her, she actually looks a little scared. Catra sighs.

"You showed me what you can do in battle. I trust you to handle it, and I need to not indulge Lashor's meddling any longer," Catra says. Adora furrows her brow, consulting Catra's expression for a long moment.

"It was a test?" she questions. Not exactly, but Catra already gave her the reasoning for the fight. This is the reasoning for her change in decision afterwards. She shrugs.

"And a good training exercise. We should do it again occasionally," Catra says. Adora looks wary.

"When I've mentally prepared, maybe," Adora almost agrees. Catra pauses, tilting her head as she consults Adora. Adora looks a little bashful. She looks away for a moment and then looks back to Catra. "Did I hurt you?" she asks in a softer voice. Oh. Has it been guilt tonight that's spawning all this?

Catra stands. Adora's eyebrows raise as Catra places one hand on the table, trailing her claws over it as a reminder of what she's capable of as she circles the table so she can come to a halt right in front of Adora's chair. Said chair is facing the table, so Catra kicks the leg, not enough to move it under Adora's weight – that would hurt her foot – but Adora takes the hint and scoots her chair back, turning it to Catra as she does so. Catra's foot nudges Adora's ankle now, and Adora blinks up at her, seeming a bit stunned, as Catra steps between her legs so she's as close as she can be and then reaches up. Adora's eyes go wide as Catra reaches for the tie of her robe despite how it's obvious Catra is wearing her nightshift underneath it.

She shrugs out of her robe and lets it fall to the floor. She'll make Adora pick it up later. Adora is blushing now, not seeming to know where to look, because Catra's dress is too transparent for them to be standing this close. Magicats have different cultural ideas around the body than most humans, *especially* those from Bright Moon. It's not practical to be ashamed of it in the Waste when you frequently have to shed clothes to shake out sand.

"Adora," Catra commands her attention, holding her hand out. Adora glances down at it, seems to realize she glances at her boobs on the way and then refuses to look up from Catra's

hand, cautiously taking it.

Catra guides her hand to her other wrist.

“Small bruise from the pin,” she lists off, placing Adora’s hand over it. Adora’s hand tenses for a moment and then her hand comes to life.

Her fingertips are so gentle as they run over the slight mark she likely can’t even see through her fur. Catra lets her do it for a moment before reaching for her hand again, pulling it to her shoulder and trailing it up towards her neck. Adora seems like she wants to resist, but right before Catra’s hand would reach it, Adora actually reaches for it herself. Her fingers are even *gentler* running down the side of her neck, and a shiver runs through Catra.

“No bruising, I think, but I kept feeling it for a while at first. That was audacious,” Catra tells her. She sees the guilt flash across Adora’s face. Catra covers her hand and guides it down her body. Adora blushes again as it skates her curves until it reaches a spot on the front of her hip. Her hand is harsh in comparison to the last two touches as her fingertips feel it out.

“It’s going to bruise, I think. From your sword, if I recall. Maybe your knee,” Catra continues. Adora swallows. “Go down,” Catra orders, and Adora does, running her hand down her leg. A tremor runs through Catra that she suppresses as Adora’s hand passes the edge of her shift and knows exactly where it’s going, wrapping around the back of her shin and cupping it.

“When you swept my legs out from under me. *Definitely* going to bruise, your boots are hard,” Catra says. Adora looks down at her hand wrapped around Catra for a long moment before she looks up at her. Her expression is so waiting, so *open*, so unsure how to feel.

“I can get these – well, *most* of these – from any good spar. And I was prepared for them. You clearly knew how to not *really* hurt me,” Catra tells her. Adora blushes, her eyes skittering away, accidentally landing on Catra’s chest, and then turning quickly away. Catra just barely manages not to purr. Well, good to know her body is still distracting. She never really got to feel it appreciated when she was “in her prime”. She never minds the gray in her coat, really, not outside of when she swore Adora was admiring a pure black one untouched by age, but her body has also started to shift how it holds weight, some. All the more reason she needs to diversify her training to ensure she does not fall behind like her mother did.

“I’m sorry about your throat. I just wanted to end it before I really hurt you and it’s all I could think of,” Adora murmurs. Catra’s tail twitches behind her, the hem of her dress dancing against the back of her knees.

“I’m not giving you permission to do it again, but I didn’t ask you to do what I gave you permission for, I asked you to *win*,” Catra says. Adora glances up, biting her lip. When she’s looking up at her with those doe eyes, hand still on her body, Catra has an idea for other teeth that could be on her lip.

“I’m okay, Adora. You did what I wanted. I doubt anyone is going to attack me in the next few days and you’ll be more useful ridding me of the thorn in my side,” Catra says. Adora

takes a deep breath and nods. She releases Catra's leg and Catra immediately mourns the contact.

It's fine. She already knows what she's doing tonight.

"I won because you weren't trying to choke me," Adora admits. Catra's lips quirk. Adora wasn't trying to choke her either.

She knows what she means, though. They walked into that battle with Catra on the defensive. She could have blinded Adora if she felt like aiming her claws right. That wasn't the point of the spar, though, and she didn't want to hurt Adora.

Adora didn't want to hurt her.

"I know. But you didn't have your sword either," Catra acknowledges, because that wasn't Adora aiming to kill, either. Adora inclines her head without looking at her. She is eye level with her chest and trying to avoid looking at it. Catra clears her throat.

"My robe," she says and Adora practically scrambles to bend down and collect it, quickly standing and helping Catra pull it on to her amusement. She gets a few more brushes of Adora's hands against her before it is fixed in place and tied at her waist. Adora straightens, finally able to make eye contact with her again.

"Do you require anything else tonight, princess?" Adora asks, and Catra's lips quirk.

"No, enjoy your evening," she instructs, and then she steps back, giving Adora room to process and finish her dinner as she turns away, reaching up to pull her mane out from beneath the collar of the robe as she walks back to her room, dinner basically finished after she ate most of it quickly to avoid Adora avoiding *her*.

She'd rather have some time alone in her room while Adora finishes her largely untouched meal.

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Adora knew exactly what Catra was going to do when she saw the swish of her tail and hips as she walked away. She takes her time at dinner, and she's surprised to find that out in the common area, she never hears a thing, not even when she approaches her own door. Catra could just be done by the time she walks deeper into the apartment, though. Maybe there really is something about the acoustics between their rooms that conducts her moans and Adora shouldn't reasonably be able to hear Catra.

Adora takes down her hair, brushing it out and using it as an opportunity to relax before bed. She's just about to climb into it when she hears a sound that's very clear, but she still has to freeze and listen to it for a few seconds for her brain to process it.

It's her bell. It's kept by Catra's bedside and she rarely ever rings it. She has a proper pull mounted on the wall connected to a bell outside of the apartment to call a servant in for material needs. This small bell is specifically to get Adora's attention without Catra needing to yell, and Catra is largely independent in everything she does. Adora is pretty sure the last time she heard Catra ring it was when she forgot to close the curtains and she was half asleep, mumbling and asking Adora to close them for her. Calling in a servant would have let the sun assault her for a few extra seconds, which would have been unacceptable.

Cautiously, Adora leaves her room, opening Catra's door and looking inside. Catra is lying on her bed, a single candle lit on her bedside.

"I distinctly remember you saying you didn't require anything else, Princess," Adora says. Catra breathes a soft laugh and lifts her arm.

"I didn't. Come and close the door," she says. Adora is no less confused, but she follows orders, approaching Catra's bedside. "Closer," Catra adds. Adora follows until her knees are against the edge of the bed and she can't get any closer without climbing inside.

Catra sits up slowly, and then she leans forward, against Adora's chest. Oh. Adora lifts her arms and cautiously wraps them around Catra to hug her.

Catra starts purring. Loudly. She already was a little bit, but now she does a *lot* as she melts into Adora's chest.

"Closer," she murmurs into her shirt. Adora huffs good-naturedly, lips twitching, as she shifts back so she can turn and sit beside Catra. Catra immediately turns to follow her, half-curling up in her lap with her legs still trapped under the blanket. She rests her head on Adora's shoulder, nuzzling it a little before letting out a gentle sigh and stilling there. Adora holds her, not sure what else she wants.

She doesn't seem to want anything else. That's… That's a lot, especially when she remembers what Catra *definitely* just did, and how intense things got earlier, and how Adora learned to hold a throat like that.

Catra has never asked to be held afterwards. She doesn't know why she wants it tonight, but it's good she's seeking her out at least, right? It's one thing to let Adora hug her, or even hug Adora herself after dinner. To call her into her room just for cuddles is something Adora never thought she would do, but she can't deny how nice it is. She doesn't get physical affection any more than Catra does. She reaches one hand up, petting over Catra's hair, and Catra trills gently. Her breathing is steady, like she's ready to fall asleep right there.

If Adora thought a divine force was toying with her before, it's laughing at her now. She has never been more confused about their relationship as Catra settles in against her chest like it was a pillow made for her.

"You can go when you're tired," Catra murmurs into her shirt. Adora blinks at the dark curtains across from her and then glances down at Catra's ears. One has a significant gray streak along the back compared to the other. Adora reaches up and runs her thumb over it. Catra's ear twitches, but it doesn't pin back or really pull away from her touch.

“You're sure?” Adora asks, voice gentle. She doesn’t know what she’s really proposing. Catra’s ears do twitch back. Adora runs a hand over one of her lighter hair streaks instead. Catra has greyed in streaks rather than scattered hairs like a human would. Adora has kind of always wanted to pet them, wondering if they felt different than the rest of her hair.

They do, they’re fuzzier.

“Yes,” Catra tells her, tucking her face against her collarbone and going quiet to purr there.

Well, the purr certainly threatens to lure Adora to sleep, but she thinks she can stay awake for a bit longer.

Chapter End Notes

They’re so abnormal I’m obsessed with them
-The Dry Tower is a “prison” where, as the name suggests, the well is limited and people are sometimes sent there just to die as an example, but if they survive their sentence they hobble away weakened.
-Catra’s weapon is a chain-sickle/kusarigama courtesy of Meta as a way to make her whip deadly. It’s not the most practical weapon in real life, but the sickle’s ability to mimic the magicat fighting style with their claws to compensate for harder to penetrate armor is important to magicats, so there is an order that trains with the weapon and passes down the art. Catra trained with them when she was young and sheltered.
-Okay so fun fact about Liege, it can either be someone you serve or someone who serves you depending on the usage, and it having both those meanings means it’s the most appropriate “demeaning” thing Catra can say to Adora considering Adora is both above and below her in different steps of the political and royal hierarchy. This also means that the title of the fic is “spoken” by both Catra and Adora about the other.

# Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

Heehee possessive queens 🥰🥰

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora brought Junipurr on her lizard hunting party.

Catra didn't know this until they'd already left. She didn't check Adora's work, she trusts her left hand implicitly. What she doesn't trust is that little kitten with a wandering eye. Junipurr is actually only a few years younger, but her black coat is pristine like she should still be sleeping at her parents' feet. She has a long-haired coat and Catra didn't *used* to be jealous of it until she saw Adora absently watching Junipurr's tail sway at a party and suddenly she needed Adora at her side and to be on the far end of the event.

She has no idea why Adora would bring her. She's an archer, if Catra recalls – and she does, because she has kept an ear trained on her since. She could be of use, but this isn't an ideal mission for her. Adora must have a unique strategy if she's bringing her, so did Adora come up with it and look for the tool for the job, or did she know who she wanted to bring and made it work? Catra suddenly feels embarrassed by the way she clung to Adora the day before she left, like the kitten that Junipurr manages to look.

Unlike Catra, Adora hasn't been celibate. She highly doubts she has had a partner in Halfmoon that Catra is unaware of, but she was betrothed once. Then the Horde came and Adora broke it off to focus on the war. She told Catra once it was a marriage that she was expecting to grow love for, so she had no interest in resuming it after the war, and by then she was a princess and above her ex-fiancé's station.

In the Waste, things like that matter less, and companionship is a far cry from the severity of an engagement. Adora and her little ride-along are back with Lashor's leg in tow, along with the tails of many more of his men, so Catra decides a small celebration is in order. Lizardfolk tails may grow back, but legs only grow over in stumps and tend to have shed complications. She doubts Lashor will be a problem for her again. Even if he wanted to try, he'll know by now that the next level of punishment is the Dry Tower, and he doesn't stand a shot of escaping it if Catra sends her dog after him again.

It was Adora's planning and leadership that got them the bounties Lashor had been hoarding along with the gruesome trophies, so Catra thinks a palace-wide dinner is in order, not quite as fancy as a feast, but they certainly fill the Great Hall. The best thing about these kinds of dinners is that there's designated seating by rank even if there aren't assigned placements. Adora's hunting party is sat nearby since it's a celebration for them, but they're not right beside them. Junipurr hasn't dared to be closer than a few seats down from Adora.

Catra isn't inclined to give speeches tonight, that will come later when she has had trophies fashioned from what Adora brought back and she presents it to her, but everybody knows why they're here. Everybody sees Adora at the head of the table, there not to guard, but to be the center of attention. Adora knows it even, she has worn her ceremonial armor.

"Would you prefer something lighter just for Halfmoon ceremonies?" Catra asks Adora as she clinks slightly reaching for her chalice. She has removed the gauntlets for the meal, and her hands look a little comically small compared to the rest of her, but Catra can't deny Adora looks good in every set of armor she dons. The primarily-leather armor she wears out in the Waste wouldn't be suitable for someone with her title to wear to any ceremonial occasions, but this is the Waste, not Bright Moon, and she doesn't need armor quite this opulent. The gleaming gold and white is impressive, as is the intricate metalwork decorating every piece, but there are *many* pieces.

"You can find platemail craftsmen here?" Adora asks, tilting her head slightly like she never thought about it before. Truthfully, Catra has been meaning to ask for a while but didn't want to insult her station at first when Adora is already being brought to her heel. She rolls her eyes.

"I'm sure I'll think of something, even if it involves commissioning someone in Bright Moon for a set mixing the Knight-Princess requirements with magicat styles. If you're going to be in my court this long, you should dress like it," Catra says. Adora immediately shoves a bite in her mouth so large that Catra is surprised she doesn't choke. Does she not have a gag reflex?

Catra does, but she's sure she could accommodate that too in the right circumstances. Adora has to chew for a bit, but eventually she puts down her fork.

"I like my armor. I worked hard to earn it. I've been wearing it for years. If there's some occasions where it's not acceptable and I don't have anything else that's suitable, then I suppose a replacement would do, but it's not like I'm ever wearing it for more than a day," Adora says. Catra could point out she wore it for most of the time Duncan was here, but she holds her tongue.

If she's honest, she wanted to mark Adora, and now Adora has rejected this, she finds herself at a loss for anything pleasant to say.

"Very well," she agrees, and then takes her own *reasonable* sized bite.

Adora doesn't notice. She goes right back to chatting with anybody in her vicinity. She's very personable and cheerful despite everything they went through in the war. She honestly has the personality of a princess – not in the Waste, ruling takes a heart of steel here, but Catra could see her thriving pretty much anywhere else, and yet she has given no indication thus far that she bucks under this assignment.

A bitter part of Catra supposes that if she were to allow Junipurr near Adora, it would give Adora one more reason to stay with her, but one of the few warm parts of her wants Adora to have another reason. One day they're going to have to talk about it. Probably this summer. Angella didn't set any terms for how long Adora would be here when she gifted Adora to

Catra, though no part of her imagined it would be permanent. It was just said that she was being assigned there to help Catra keep peace in the Waste and protect her as it would be sore repayment for her efforts during war to leave her fighting for her own life after making herself such a big target at Bright Moon's expense. The Waste is never truly calm, but she doesn't know if Angella really understood that when assigning Adora.

Catra has maybe missed Adora terribly in the fortnight she was away and lost too much in her life to not think of what feeling like that *all the time* would feel like. She barely stops her lip from curling when they're leaving for the night and she finishes a side conversation to turn and find Adora's party has caught up with them, including Junipurr, who is talking to her with bright eyes.

Catra truthfully has no idea of her intentions and proclivities, but the way her tail always sways in conversation with Adora and her eyes often dilate around her gives her a hint. She steps closer and she sees Junipurr spot her, eyes darting to her for a moment before she looks back to Adora and swishes her tail to curl around her right side in a respectful nod.

"Adora, I just wanted to say thank you again for giving me a shot," Junipurr is saying goodbye as Catra approaches, as if she has the right to forgo Adora's title. Most people here do, honestly, but *Catra* didn't give Junipurr permission to do so.

"Oh, of course. You were invaluable," Adora says, a furrow in her brow as she glances up and sees Catra a moment before she reaches them. "I have to retire for now, but please enjoy the rest of your night. You earned it," Adora promises, nodding her head to Junipurr, who smiles and once again sways her tail with pride as Adora steps away. Catra turns sharply, walking towards the entrance now Adora is following her. It wouldn't be suitable for her to glare down one of the warriors she is supposed to be celebrating. That's how you get disloyal men – or in this case, women, the only threat she has when it comes to Adora.

She stills feels better when they step into the quiet of the palace outside of the hall. Well, relative quiet. Adora clinks as she follows just a few feet behind her. At this point, that sound is almost comforting to her. They walk in silence, Catra maybe swishing her hips like Junipurr does even if it's less impressive with her short coat. Her tail is *almost* black.

"She thinks you don't like her, you know. She thought I was going to kick her off when I took over," Adora finally says. Catra's ears twitch back.

"Why would you do that?" she asks, voice completely neutral.

"Probably because you don't like her," Adora says, voice amused. Catra flushes, suddenly grateful Adora is behind her. She scoffs and refuses to acknowledge that.

"Is she a good fighter?" she asks even though she knows she isn't going to like the answer.

"Yeah. One of the best at accommodating for the winds with her bow. It's not a small task," Adora says. Catra growls under her breath. Adora coughs pointedly, so she hears it.

"She doesn't treat your rank appropriately. It disrespects me to disrespect my guard. You're above that," Catra says. All of that could technically be true.

“We’ve bled together,” Adora points out, reasonably. Catra would certainly *hope* not or Junipurr isn’t as good as Adora says, but she knows what she means. When fighting, unless there’s a strong reason not to, people become familiar in a way that lingers. Catra has experienced it some, but her true crown is usually enough for people to still behave around her. Adora’s crown is only as real as Catra insists it is.

“I still hold standards,” Catra says.

“That would be news to me,” Adora chuckles, and Catra feels momentarily murderous, but Adora certainly isn’t the subject of it. “Is there something I should know about her?” Adora asks.

“That she’s beneath acting the way she does with you,” Catra scoffs. There’s a moment’s pause, and then Adora’s clinking gets a little louder and Catra suddenly freezes as Adora’s hand takes her wrist.

“Are you referring to her admiration?” Adora says, which is such a *Bright Moon* way of phrasing it. Catra growls back. They’re in a hallway, this is *not* the place to have this discussion. “She’s young. I’ve helped train her. It’s not unusual. I had quite the affection for one of the knights who trained me. She was twice my age, but I’ve always preferred older woman. I won’t begrudge Junipurr for the same,” Adora lists off.

Catra barely stops herself from asking if Adora is insulting her. She might be doing the opposite – she might be making it clear Catra couldn’t reach her interest.

“Should I be concerned for Clawdeen, then?” Catra asks, bitterly. Adora laughs. The sound is beautiful in the dark night of the hallway.

“Too old, and I certainly hope you don’t think she feels that way about me,” Adora says, and Catra relaxes a little, because Clawdeen is twelve years her senior, so if it has to be at least a margin younger than that, then Catra isn’t… absurdly out of reach. Especially not looking the way war aged her.

“She doesn’t,” Catra says before Adora gets any ideas, and then she starts walking. Adora lets her hand slide from her grip.

Well, this has given her entirely too much to think about. She does tend to spiral without a war to distract her.

Maybe Lashor *will* act up again.

--

Catra asks Adora to join her after they’re both changed for the night. Adora doesn’t know what to expect, especially after *that* conversation, but when she walks into Catra’s bedroom, she’s just sat at her vanity with a robe mercifully covering her nightshift as she brushes her

hair. Catra glances up, briefly making eye contact in the mirror before going back to her work. With her mane, it will take a while.

“Sit anywhere,” she instructs. There aren’t exactly a lot of places to sit in Catra’s bedroom considering there’s a lounge just outside the door and an office beside that which usually have seating covered, but there is a bench stretched along the foot of the bed so Adora moves to sit on that, watching the brush pass through Catra’s hair.

Catra… doesn’t speak. Doesn’t ask for anything. The mirror isn’t even angled so she can look at her in it, though Adora is visible in the corner of her eye as Adora sits facing her, waiting. Adora takes a moment to just observe her. She seems relaxed now, far more relaxed than she was at dinner. Maybe she was getting overwhelmed. It might explain her snapping about Junipurr. Adora knows she finds it insulting to her station, but it really is harmless. She knows how she would feel if someone – anyone – gave Catra such attention, though.

That’s a bad thought. That’s a thought that leads to her thinking she was right about Catra saying her name at night and she really isn’t. The one night they almost fell asleep together was… a fluke. Adora pushed Catra to her limit in battle that day, she needed comfort, and by virtue of her life circumstances, she had no one else to provide it. Adora waited until Catra seemed to have been lulled to sleep and then eased her down into her sheets and went back to her own bed. Sitting with Catra in her lap gave her plenty of time to mentally prepare a plan for how she was going to handle Lashor and by the next day, she was basically ready to go. Maybe Catra wants to do that again tonight. She has probably been lonely as the only one in the apartment, her replacement guards stationed outside.

There were two of them, because just one wasn’t enough to replace Adora. She’s very proud of that.

“Princess,” Adora calls softly, and Catra looks up, pausing her brushing and seeming surprised Adora spoke at all despite how she was the one to call her to the room. “I can stay until you’re ready for bed, but I have a bandage I need to change every morning and night. I can go take care of it now and then come back when I’m done if you’d rather not be alone,” Adora carefully proposes to avoid making it sound like she’s assuming she can stay or *begging* to bed her.

Catra blinks at her. The hairbrush *clacks* as Catra sets it down on the nightstand without looking, standing and crossing to where Adora sits.

“Why didn’t you say anything?” she demands, suddenly worried. Adora’s brows lift.

“I told you I had an injury.” It was one of the first things she said. She reported that Lashor had been dealt with, what she brought back, and that there had been only a few injuries in the process.

“You told me it was *minor* and didn’t need any attention,” Catra corrects her. Adora frowns.

“Well, yes. It has already been treated. It’s just a cut to my leg. Lashor was using a spiked whip that managed to catch in my armor. I do still sometimes forget that I don’t have the protection of platemail,” Adora explains. Catra’s face screws up with displeasure.

“Adora, if you need a bandage, you are to *tell me*,” she orders like Adora hid a broken leg from her. Adora blinks up at her, stunned, and Catra huffs. “Show me,” she orders. Adora pauses, but she bends to lift her pant leg, carefully sliding it back so it bunches around her thigh rather than all gathering at her more delicate knee.

“It’s not bad,” Adora says, but Catra doesn’t seem to believe her, because she kneels to inspect her right leg. Adora blushes as Catra takes her ankle in her hand and carefully turns it so her bandaged calf can rotate. She doesn’t know she has ever seen Catra on her knees before in all the years that they have fought together. She looks down at her often, but normally because Catra is lounging on a throne – or a regular chair that she *treats* like a throne – and Adora is standing guard over her. This… is not that.

Catra brings her back to reality by peeling the bandage back to look at the wound itself.

“I still need to get a replacement,” Adora protests, because her pant leg shouldn’t be rubbing against it for the walk to the bathroom at this stage of scabbing. It could flake off and start bleeding again. Catra chuffs.

“Hush. I will get you a replacement. You aren’t moving,” Catra orders, turning her ankle again so she can complete a proper inspection. Adora forces herself to hold still and not shift where she sits, because part of her really wants to squirm for some reason.

“It’s minor,” Adora reinforces now Catra is looking at it and can see that. Catra is silent, looking down at her leg for a long moment. Then she suddenly stands.

“Stay here. I’ll get you a bandage and clean it for you,” Catra starts, immediately turning away and leaving the room.

“I’m supposed to be guarding *you*,” Adora calls after her as she leaves.

“You’ve not supposed to hide injuries,” Catra yells back from further in the apartment. Adora huffs.

“I didn’t hide it, I told you,” Adora calls back, because *really*, she’s fine. She told her when she arrived and she told her again when it became relevant. Catra doesn’t reply, so she might finally be out of earshot. Adora looks down at her leg. For some reason, the hair on only the right one is standing up as if reaching for Catra’s touch to come back. Adora closes her eyes and wills her body to calm. She has been bandaged plenty, even by Catra once during the war. Adora hadn’t fallen quite so deeply for her then, though, and there was nothing intimate about the setting.

All this talk tonight has gone to her head and none of it was directed at her. Catra had no reaction to Adora’s assurances that Junipurr was too young for her. She’s probably just insulted and doesn’t want Adora to split her attention from her post. Adora does wonder if Catra would approve of it with the right partner. She can’t imagine who would be more convenient than another member of her guard who lives in the castle, though. She still occasionally receives proposals amongst the letters from Bright Moon, but she told Catra that she prefers the magicat approach to romance and it hasn’t come up much. One came amongst Glimmer’s letters with many annotations provided by the princess herself and Adora kept it

just to laugh to herself when she's missing her friend. She wonders what Catra would think of it.

The bedroom door opens and Adora looks up to find Catra edging inside with maybe more medical supplies than a healing cut warrants, no matter how deep.

"I assume you *have* seen a doctor," Catra says. Adora's lips quirk.

"Yes. I'm merely to refrain from fighting or sparring for the next few days if I can. I can continue normal duties or I would have addressed it immediately," Adora promises, even if she personally thinks that she *did* address it.

"You should have addressed it immediately anyway," Catra scowls as she approaches and kneels before Adora again, setting down the supplies on the bench beside Adora.

"I can move. You shouldn't be on the floor," Adora quickly offers. This just- isn't proper. Catra scoffs.

"I will be on the floor, because *I* will be the one treating this wound going forward. Someone who will give it the proper gravity should be ensuring its closing properly," Catra corrects her. Adora feels something flutter in her heart as Catra takes the rag she wetted before returning and delicately dabs around the scabbing to clear the sweat from the day.

"Catra. Look at it. It's not that bad," Adora says. Catra growls under her breath, but she sets aside the rag and places her hand on Adora's knee instead, looking down. At least the shiver that runs through Adora at the touch is mostly contained to her spine and arms, which Catra can't see the hair standing up on. Catra lets out a sigh and finally looks up at Adora's face.

Catra's mismatched eyes, catching the light and sparkling up at her in the midst of an expression nothing short of raw and open, makes Adora's breath entirely leave her chest.

"I know, but I worried about you for days. This was the first we've been apart for more than a few hours in years, and I thought you came home safe. I will care for this, okay? Morning and evening, like you care for me," Catra murmurs to her.

Adora's mouth is incredibly dry. She's not sure how she's supposed to open it to reply, really, but after two attempts to swallow, she manages it.

"Yes, Princess. May we do it on the couch next time so you don't have to kneel?" Adora manages to agree. She might not make it through the day if she starts it by seeing Catra kneel before her again. Catra's lips quirk.

"Very well," she agrees, and then she looks back to Adora's leg and sets to drying it for the wrapping. Adora isn't used to being touched like this anymore – if she was ever used to touch at all – and it feels like her skin is tingling everywhere. Maybe she won't survive this arrangement regardless of location, but she's already *craving* it. She sees now why Catra called her into her room just to feel someone holding her, now. She almost wishes she needed more attention, but it's for the best that Catra isn't kneeling before her long.

She hopes Catra plans for her to leave when she retires tonight, because she really needs some time alone.

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After a week of being banned from the training yard, Adora seems to think she has something to make up, because she requests time to train near-daily. Some of it is with Catra, but Adora does need to go against a litany of styles given Catra's is too unique to be directly applicable often, and Catra does need *rest* sometimes. On those occasions, Catra waits on the balcony above the main training yard, often watching as much as she's working. She does have *ruling* to do, and as long as they're internal matters, she can meet with anyone in her cabinet from here. They're still surrounded by her men to protect them while Adora is busy.

Truthfully, Adora draws a crowd. She has a tendency to challenge that crowd, and anyone in the palace interested in trying their hand against her will come to watch until Adora's eyes happen to land on them one day.

Maybe the battle with Lashor made her restless, actually. She has gotten a taste of bloodshed again and seems eager to prove that the scratch really meant *nothing* to her.

Ah, that might be the issue, actually. Catra insisted on caring for it for the few days it still needed to be wrapped, maybe even keeping it wrapped an extra day. Adora might want to prove to her that she's more than capable now, but the way she comes alive in the ring shows she takes great pleasure in the process. Sometimes Catra can't even focus on what she's supposed to be doing, head turned to the yard below to watch her knight beat her own men. It's not just beating, it's crushing them to the dirt and *glowing* with victory, laughing with joy when her blood gets pumping enough and sometimes even seeming to pout when her opponent yields too early, too easily.

It's probably good that Catra is watching from this high up, away from the crowd, because the display is doing frankly obscene things to her as Adora gloats and Catra is suddenly considering putting her on a leash so she'd get a few days to *breathe*. She could easily stop arranging her schedule to accommodate this, but then she wouldn't get to watch Adora charging her opponent and slamming them to the ground, relentless attacking every time they try to stand until they yield, the entire crowd cheering as Adora beams and helps up her opponent. She drinks in the excitement and fear her knight commands as Adora looks around the crowd to select her next victim, some people shying away after seeing her in action and others leaning forward eagerly. As Adora slowly turns around the ring, her eyes drift up and Catra swears they make eye contact even across the distance for a moment.

A shiver passes through Catra. She wishes she was in the ring, but that wouldn't leave her in a state suitable for anyone to see at this moment.

Catra raises her hand slowly and despite the distance *sees* Adora following her gesture as she points into the crowd behind her. Adora whips her head around, and the onlookers also look

in the direction Catra pointed. At this distance, it's impossible to tell who she's pointing to and she isn't actually pointing to *anyone*, she's just purring at Adora so immediately following her point. Adora seems to pick someone out, pointing to him as he freezes and then turning her head up to Catra to confirm.

Sure, why not. Catra drops her hand and Adora beams as she turns back to her new opponent – the tallest and broadest soldier surrounding the ring, it seems, and Catra wonders what it means that Adora thought she wanted her to fight the burliest opponent for her.

Not that she isn't looking forward to it, but she does wonder as he shoulders through to get a sword from the edge of the ring. Catra sits back as Adora showboats her way to the center of the yard, seeming to bounce on the balls of her feet as she waits. Her opponent selects an axe rather than a sword and comes to stand at the far end of the ring. Nothing happens. Adora turns her head and looks up at Catra. Oh.

She's feeling *very* warm, sitting forward and clearing her throat so she can swallow down her purr to speak.

"For glory," she commands, booming her voice to the courtyard below. The crowd gathered cheers as the two soldiers clash and Catra's breath catches in her throat.

She's purring and she doesn't lean back to settle in for the match. No, Adora makes sure she's on the edge of her seat for the entire thing, hand flying to grip the railing when he manages to throw Adora back and charges her to close in, but before Catra can shoot to her feet, Adora shocks her by dropping to the ground and rolling towards his feet as he charges, swinging her sword into his shins and causing him to stumble and fall over her. She is ready for it and quickly rolls to her feet, not pausing for a moment so she can take advantage of his fall. Catra isn't as quick to move on, because that's *her move*. Not exactly, she would drop and then use her chain to pull her opponent off their feet so she could attack them with her sickle after standing up, her opponent too busy trying to free their legs of the chain to mirror her, but Adora took what she saw Catra do a dozen times in war and adapted it for her own style and the situation.

This is going to have to be the last fight, because Catra needs to go be alone after this.

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Catra is in the bathroom and has been for a while. Adora knows she's wet brushing and that can take a long time, but she has been trying to work herself up to something and dinner is here now, so she has to interrupt Catra either way. She knocks on the door, glancing back at the set table.

"Princess?" Adora calls. There's a moment of silence.

“Come in,” Catra responds, voice hollow through the wood. Adora swallows and braces herself for *whatever* she may see as she pushes the door open.

Catra is sat in a comfortable wooden bench that slides over the top of the tub, a tray with an assortment of brushes beside her and the tub half-filled below her with a light haze of soap bubbles floating across the surface. She has draped a towel over her lap but is otherwise naked as she brushes down her thigh, the towel scrunched up out of the way so she’s really only covering a few critical inches at best. Adora wills her heartrate down as Catra glances up from her brush. She’s using the dry brush, so she’s almost done. When she has the time, she prefers wet-brushing to bathing in the tub because it dries more comfortably. It just takes an absorbent brush dipped it into water so she can brush oils and sand out of her coat. It’s a more sensible way to bathe in the Waste that can have limited access to water, and even if hers is practically infinite, it’s more pleasant for her. When she’s done, she brushes out the evaporating bubbles with the dry brush and is ready to go.

“Dinner is here,” Adora manages to say in a normal voice. Catra has little shame about her body, but her eyes feel like they’re lingering on Adora’s reaction, which makes Adora nervous about what her face – or scent signals, for that matter – is doing.

She’s just- Catra has no idea what a *temptation* she is. She’s gorgeous, so soft with streaks – both dark stripes and grey strands – that Adora has wanted to run her hands along for a long time. That damned fancy night shift she wears guarantees Adora has gotten a good view of the tempting sway of her chest and the blush of her nipples. Adora feels her hand twitch by her side and tenses her entire arm to still it. The temptation of Catra’s body is far from new, but the way Catra looked down at her in the training yard from her throne made Adora yearn to do anything she could to earn her approval, affection, *pride*.

“I’m almost done. Just have the servants set the table and go,” Catra tells her, eyes still on Adora, slowly tracing down her arm. Adora forces herself to unclench her muscles with a twitch of her fingers.

“I already sent them away. What kind of guard do you think I am to leave people unguarded in your private chambers?” Adora asks. Catra’s eyes meet hers, sparkling.

“Oh, I know you’re very dedicated,” she purrs, and then she turns back to her leg, straightening it out and pointing her toe as she hooks her foot over the edge of the tub so she can brush her calf. Adora stands there, suddenly realizing she’s watching *everything*, but when Catra bends the brush down her leg, these little rolls appear in her stomach and they make Adora want to bury her fingers in her stomach fluff even more.

She felt the thrill of being at Catra’s beck and call in the ring, and now she’s having *very* un-queenly thoughts. Adora tries to tear her eyes away. She fails, because Catra doesn’t look back up to her and thus gives her no deterrent strong enough.

Adora’s breathing is getting a little heavy. She clears her throat.

“I have a request of you,” she states, wincing a little when her voice comes out a little too forceful. Catra looks up, seeming surprised, and Adora ashamedly looks down, wishing she

hadn't put her sword away yet so she could rest her hand on the pommel and anchor herself with it.

"Well, if you want it before I'm dressed, it will have to be a short list," Catra teases and Adora's cheeks, heart, *core* flame, eyes widening as she keeps them locked on the floor in shock.

"I- That's not-" She might be choking a little. She might be suffocating. She might be burning alive.

*Oh, please*.

"Relax, Adora. What do you want?"

And of course, no. Does Catra really not know Adora would drop to her knees for her here and now? That there are so many other ways Adora wishes to serve her? Adora forces herself to just focus on the stones beneath her and the words coming out of her mouth.

"It has been too long since I felt the sting of defeat," she says and Catra's brush freezes in the middle of its pass in the corner of her eye. A moment later, Catra lowers her leg and leans back, looking at Adora. Adora still can't look at her, not when she's *naked*.

"You want to fight?" Catra asks. Adora nods.

"And I want to lose," she adds. Catra's tail stirs, but only briefly, and Adora can't decipher the movement in the corner of her eye while partially blocked by the tub.

"That will be slightly harder to arrange than my own loss, I admit," Catra jokes. *That* causes Adora to snap her gaze up, frowning.

"You can defeat me," she immediately refutes. Catra rolls her eyes and sets the brush down.

Then she stands, barely remembering to grab the towel and certainly not using it to *cover* herself, instead catching it and running it quickly down her torso and arms without breaking eye contact.

"I can, yes, but you know a training yard is not the ideal conditions for me, nor is anything nonlethal. You want a battle like before?" she asks. Adora hesitates, grateful for the serious topic to distract her as Catra steps out of the tub.

"I want whatever battle conditions it will take for you to defeat me, and I don't want to harm you any more than I already have. I have been *trying* to find an opponent who can best me, but I find the number who can put me in my place lacking," Adora admits. Catra stills.

Then she walks forward, *glides*, until she's right before Adora and can reach up, fingertips and claws stroking along Adora's jaw as her heart stops and Catra pulls her to sway in closer with just the lightest of pressure against her face

"Your place is by my side, Adora, but that can be arranged beneath me, as well. Just give me a few days to prepare," Catra promises her.

Adora barely hears the words. She's too busy screaming at her body to not move, not sway any closer, not let her gaze drift down, not to Catra's mouth and not to below. Mouth? Catra doesn't even have one, she can't kiss, that's for sure. Adora should stop thinking about how badly she needs to do it. She- She'll get her battle. She'll get the thrill of the fight, and the thrill of *Catra*, and it will be enough to tide her until the next touch like this.

She's not certain Catra has ever touched her like this, a smile dancing at the corner of her lips before she pulls away and turns to get dressed in the clothes set out for her on the dressing table.

"If you have ideas for how you wish it structured, let me know," she says, as if it's possible to carry on a conversation after that. Adora has to force herself to turn her head away so her entire body stops swaying towards Catra and a touch that is no longer there. She has to swallow twice, but eventually she manages to stir her tongue.

"I'll make a list." Right now her only thoughts are on how they can celebrate a victory, but she's sure she'll need something to distract her from those thoughts when they pop up at inopportune times in public tomorrow, so she'll come up with something.

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Catra wishes she knew what someone looked like when they wanted to kiss you.

She thinks she knows. She thinks she saw all the signs, but the cold realization creeps in that she has no idea, really, but Adora *does*, and she smells interested but hasn't taken the bait even with all of Catra's flirting. She already laid it on as thick as she's comfortable doing and she can think of nothing to do other than step back and give Adora room. If that look, that *stirring* within her did mean she wanted to kiss her, well, clearly it didn't mean she actually wanted to go through with it, because she didn't. She let Catra step back and put on clothes she'd much rather be shedding, and she carries on as normal for dinner, even bidding Catra goodnight right after so there's no room for Catra to wiggle in a bit more time together tonight, which is all signs in favor of her misreading Adora's expression.

This is an area of life she has no experience in and that realization almost makes her want to call a companion immediately to come knock some experience – if not some sense – into her, but she finds no pleasure in the idea despite the jealousy she feels towards Adora's one partner in the past.

She just couldn't stand to drive Adora away. She's going to be so *alone* whenever Adora returns to her station in Bright Moon. The very thought makes her feel ill enough to almost reach for the bell and call someone – Adora to hold her, a servant to cool her forehead, she doesn't know, *anything* – but that is the dramatics of a teenager and unbecoming of a queen.

Well, she isn't allowed to have that title, anyway. The one woman who does hold it can send her into a spiral with the control she has over her happiness, though.

The last thing she expects to wake up to on the morning she and Adora are supposed to finally have their spar, the spar she has craved since Adora suggested it for the chance to be against Adora again, is a missive from Queen Angella inviting Catra to join Adora at Bright Moon Castle.

For Adora, a summons came, and sure, it's a summons for Glimmer's summer gala and clearly just to see her friends again, but an order to Adora is an order to Catra because she can go nowhere without her and doesn't want to.

She wonders if the Star Siblings will be there. It certainly fuels how hard she goes trying to rip Adora's shield off her in the battle. If Adora's focus in on war, battle, a partner who can *challenge* her, well, that Catra can provide. She's better at it than romance, anyway.

Chapter End Notes

-Adora saying it's natural to feel for the people you train with after she and Catra had the most down bad nasty battle right before she left and it just flying over Catra's head, meanwhile Catra is out here inventing problems and harlots getting in her way, is the kind of dynamic between them I live for.
-Since Adora didn't meet Catra until her late twenties, her "dating" life developed along the Bright Moon standards for marriage. Adora never naturally met someone she fell in love with, so when she was in her twenties and it hadn't happened, Angella helped arrange a marriage to another knight who would have likely been traded to the Bright Moon court as a result, but it was considered an honor to have your knight sought by Queen Angella herself (though that's not exactly the situation). She and Adora knew each other and got along well, and that's enough for a marriage of arrangement in most courts.

# Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

> I can't use my right arm or do anything with this pain flare so here have an early upload because maybe I can at least read comments 😭

See the end of the chapter for more notes

On the journey to Bright Moon, Catra wonders what Adora even sees in the Waste and why she puts up with it when there are such beautiful jungles and sunshine that *doesn't* burn in Adora's homeland, and then they actually arrive and she doesn't know how Adora ever stands the formality.

She supposes the answer to that is finding an oasis amongst pomp and circumstance.

"Adora!" Glimmer shrieks loud enough across the parlor for Catra to pin her ears back and growl, though no one pays her any mind, because they're too busy assaulting her bodyguard. Catra watches from her armchair as Glimmer, despite her small size, somehow almost manages to knock Adora off her feet throwing her arms around her in a hug. All the skirts probably contribute extra momentum to her body weight.

Catra's growl dies. She wants a hug like that. She's sad. She's jealous. She's being ignored as Bow catches up with Glimmer and throws his arms around them both.

"Oh, guys, I missed you *so much*," Adora says, shifting one arm so she can squeeze them both back. She honestly sounds close to tears. Catra feels like she's intruding. She does consider Glimmer – well, Bow more, she actually bled with him on one charge – her friends after the time that they spent together during the war, but they were commanding different armies and did not work as closely as she and Adora did. Adora worked with *all* of them, and she may be Catra's now, but she grew up in Glimmer's castle.

Catra looks away, casting her gaze out the window to the Bright Moon gardens she will always be jealous of, just like she is of the reunion happening in the center of the room. She never really forgets what these visits feel like, but it's still different to actually *feel* it. It will be like this every day, for nearly three weeks. She can't go longer away from her kingdom, and luckily Angella hasn't asked her to. The way these visits usually go is Catra splits her time between being Adora's drag-along, attending whatever duties or meetings Angella assigns her, wasting time with whatever distractions the Bright Moon royalty arranges so Adora has more time with her friends, and decompressing in the safety of her room while, once again, Adora spends time with others.

It's fine, it's only a few weeks a year at most, and it has been nearly two since they were last here. She'll survive it, take Adora back home, and luxuriate in all the ways she's *hers*.

These visits prove that she isn't, really.

"Catra!" Glimmer suddenly says, and Catra whips her head around, blinking at the trio in the middle of the room that hasn't finished hugging, exactly, but are no longer piled together, at least. Glimmer only has one arm still wrapped around Adora, and she raises the other one, beckoning at Catra.

Catra blinks at her. She makes that motion at Adora sometimes. She knows what it means, she just… wasn't expecting it. Slowly, she stands, and Glimmer just smiles and drops her other arm away from Adora.

Oh. Okay. Catra steps closer and lets Glimmer hug her. Glimmer squeezes tight like she did with Adora. Adora doesn't hug Catra this hard, even, but her hugs feel more meaningful. This is… nice, though. Catra tries to hug her back, though she can't match her enthusiasm. Glimmer gasps anyway and then squeezes her tighter for a moment.

In the background, Catra hears Bow coo. Oh. She's purring. Bow never managed to be normal about that. Catra did it for him during a quiet moment in camp after a Horde soldier managed to close in to melee range on him and he took a bad hit to his shoulder. They never acknowledged it again. At least no one acknowledges it now. Glimmer just hugs her and then Bow takes a turn too, and then for some unknown reason, Adora hugs her too, pulling Catra against her chest.

It's a good thing Catra was already purring or she would be *embarrassingly* obvious.

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Adora is a little sleep deprived, but she also missed a day full of sunshine. The Waste is honestly still bright at night thanks to the unobstructed view of the moons and stars, but it's not the same as sunshine and a cool breeze that rustles the leaves of the castle gardens. Bright Moon's summer may seem hot to Glimmer, but Adora is luxuriating in it. She's not wearing all the dress layers Glimmer is, though, she gets to wear a shirt and pants with some light armor details thrown on that would actually be useless in battle but are to display her status the same way Glimmer's skirts do.

"Either you have to come visit more or Catra has to put a garden in for you at the palace," Glimmer says, leaning back on her garden lounge and reaching up to brush her hair out of her face where it's starting to stick to her forehead a little. Adora sighs happily from where she's collapsed in the grass.

"As much as I would love it, nothing would survive," she admits. She would love more time amongst plant life – and less time in the sun – but if it's the garden over Catra, she's picking Catra.

She has a terrible, terrible fantasy where Catra stops being queen and comes to live in Bright Moon with her, but she would never actually want it to happen. She would feel unendingly sick if it did, but she does miss home.

“Your hair has lightened at least two shades since we last saw you. You need to spend more time around shade trees,” Glimmer pouts. Adora just shakes her head, smiling to herself.

“Come visit me,” she says, but she knows Glimmer just misses her. Glimmer whines.

“I can’t, I’m not bringing Angel into the Waste or leaving him with a nanny that long,” Glimmer complains, which Adora can’t begrudge her for. Right now Bow is with Angel so Adora and Glimmer can have some alone time. Later Glimmer will trade off with him, and then all of them will convene, along with Catra, for dinner – Catra’s lunch.

“Let Angella enjoy time with her grandson, then,” Adora says. Glimmer releases a wistful whine.

“She says she already uses up her energy for that on the diplomatic trips we do to other courts. Your palace is so *far*,” Glimmer says. It’s really not unreasonable, but it is much further than the distance to Plumeria she’ll admit. “Speaking of *energy*, though, are you interested in the gala tourney this year? I assumed you would be, but Mom said you might be tired after traveling,” Glimmer asks. Adora pauses, blinking up at the sky. Oh, she forgot about that. She wasn’t able to attend the gala at all last year, so she hasn’t competed in a while. It would be nice to be part of a proper tourney again. The Waste doesn’t have them. They use battle rings instead, which are fun, but Adora likes both experiences. She misses riding.

“Of course I want to,” Adora says, sitting up. “I’ll need some time to practice and a horse to borrow, though,” she says. Glimmer claps her hands together.

“I think Swift Wind is still in shape! I can’t wait to see you compete again. You’d better not go against Bow, though, I don’t want to have to choose,” Glimmer says, like Adora has any control over that and they don’t both know who she would pick.

“It’s fine, I’ll have Catra cheering for me,” Adora waves off. Glimmer rolls her eyes.

“Of course that’s most important. Are you going to wear her tabard next?” Glimmer asks, sarcastically. She looks down at Adora’s wide-eyed expression, blush coloring her cheeks. “That’s a joke, your ours unless she wants to make a proposal!” Glimmer immediately protests. Those words make Adora’s face flush red and she quickly ducks her head.

“I know, I know,” she hurriedly dismisses, heart squeezing. When she looks back up, Glimmer has her eyes narrowed.

“Did anything happen?” she asks, sounding caught between suspicion and excitement. Adora sighs.

“No. I just haven’t stopped wishing. I’m happy to serve so closely by her side. She has no interest in another, at least,” Adora admits, standing and brushing the grass damp off her

pants. Glimmer and Bow – likely even Angella and Glimmer's aunt – know of Adora's interest in Catra, but she was raised around royalty and she knows she can't make such advances herself. Unless Catra is to cross a line, she'll just watch, and want, and do her best to distinguish herself to her.

Maybe if she wins the tournament Catra will be the one to present her the trophy. Adora is grateful just for the opportunity to kneel before her.

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Adora is off playing with Angel, so Angella has mercifully called Catra to an evening lunch. Catra has only just woken up and Adora has been spending all afternoon running around in the sun probably. Both of them shift their schedules some while visiting Bright Moon, but Adora certainly does it more than Catra, so they end up on a time difference as well.

"Well-rested, Catra?" Angella asks as Catra lifts her skirts to step down onto the balcony. Her nightshift aside, she doesn't usually wear dresses. Magicats have *robes*, they're different. They're flexible, worn over a tight sand-protection layer and pants, and don't go all the way to the floor. She wears more layers and drapes than most – it's rather ostentatious in the Waste and she has to flaunt it – but she has double as many layers in Bright Moon just to avoid seeming like a peasant in comparison to others' dresses.

"I am rested," Catra comments, dryly, and Angella chuckles as Catra carefully sweeps her skirts out of the way and sits down. A light tea has been set out for them, but Catra notices a few staples on the blander side probably intended to help keep her stomach calm first thing in the morning for her. Food in Bright Moon does tend to be both a little rich and a little bland for her. Adora isn't used to it either anymore and usually has a stomach ache on day two – not the it stops her.

"I haven't booked you any engagements that start before two for the week until the ball," Angella promises. Catra doesn't bother telling her that she's usually still in bed then. It sounds lazy to diurnal folk. She'll spend an entire day sleeping when they come back to the Waste to reset her clock. She's already looking forward to it.

"I appreciate the restraint," Catra says in the same tone of voice. Angella's lips twitch.

"Adora has expressed interest in entering the tourney on Sunday before the gala," Angella says. Catra stares into the middle distance, seeing nothing but visions of her hellish future.

"What time?" she asks, hollowly.

"Eleven in the morning," Angella says, and Catra isn't *looking* at her silently laughing at her, but it's managing not to be that silent. Catra closes her eyes, suppresses a growl, and goes through all five, seven, nine stages of grief.

“May I sit in your box?” Catra asks in a completely calm voice, opening her eyes again. Angella’s lips twitch.

“Of course. Adora will be thrilled,” Angella agrees. Well, at least there’s that. Catra has to be there, because otherwise Adora will be competing as *Angella’s* knight and that’s unacceptable. If she’s sitting with Angella, at least she can delude herself that anyone who looks their way is looking to Catra as Adora’s queen, even if she’s going to be competing under Bright Moon’s banner. Maybe Catra just won’t go to bed that night. Seeing Adora fighting in full regalia will certainly wake her up.

That regalia not having Catra’s tabard over it will also stir her in a bad way, but hopefully she can avoid being too snippy with Angella in the box.

“Will Glimmer be competing?” Catra asks. Glimmer is a fighter, but not a *soldier*, and there’s a difference. Catra is also a fighter and you don’t see her entering in tournaments, but Glimmer has more of need to showboat than Catra does and comes from that culture. Catra prefers to flaunt her power quietly, *insidiously*.

“No. Bow will be,” Angella says and she really doesn’t have to explain more. She’ll be doing the same thing as Catra, but that also means she’ll be in a box with both of them, which means they’ll probably talk amongst themselves and make comments unknowingly rubbing in that Adora is ultimately a knight of Bright Moon.

She’s not. She’s *Catra’s* knight. Just plain Catra’s.

Except that she isn’t and this visit is to remind her of that, for her future sanity. Catra deigns to reach for her tea and starts in on the breakfast, because she hasn’t eaten yet and she has nasty sentiment bubbling in her heart.

“We included an invitation to the tournament with the gala invites, so a number of people will be bringing their knights if they’re not interested in competing themselves,” Angella continues, effortlessly shaking her head to shimmy her hair over her shoulder. Catra chirps and forces herself to eat a small finger cake in three bites instead of downing the entire thing at once. Adora’s manners have rubbed off on her since they usually dine together.

“Ah, the Star Siblings will be in attendance as well,” Angella comments, like she just remembered it, and Catra freezes. Slowly, her gaze lifts to Angella’s face.

“Of the gala?” she asks. Angella nods, and then she stands, sweeping away to a staging table at the back of the balcony where additional jugs are held if they need refills.

“I imagine one or two of them will compete as well, but we won’t know until they arrive since pre-registration wasn’t required,” Angella says as she bends to collect something, and then she straightens and turns around. “I *imagine* Starla would like to compete for Adora’s heart again,” she says, and Catra’s heart drops.

“No- That *can’t* be,” Catra says, even as her eyes remain locked on the ornate chest in Angella’s hands, decorated in gold with two distinctive crests on either side of the lid,

fanciful ribbons and arrangements of delicate flowers tied to each of the chest legs. Angella sits it down with a soft *clink* on the tea table and then sits behind it.

“Yes, the proposal came with their RSVP for the gala. I decided it would be best to deliver it to Adora in person when she arrived. All the flowers died but I decided to replace them for the full effect,” Angella says. Catra’s heart is either racing or only beating once a minute as she watches Angella open the chest and the scrolls baring Starla’s pledge immediately spill out.

“This is- beneath Adora. It’s insulting,” Catra spits out as she glares at the ink, which she swears is purple, somewhat iridescent. Ink like that isn’t cheap. Starla put everything she could afford into rekindling her engagement. Angella arches a brow.

“They knew each other before and were considered a reasonable match. It could be deemed appropriate, especially if the Stars invest appropriately into the proposal and wedding,” Angella says and Catra’s stomach drops *again*, turning into pure turmoil as Angella reaches into the box and pulls forward a single piece of paper, containing a sketch.

It’s Starla’s knight’s banner joined with Adora’s made up family crest she got when her title was bestowed. It’s roughly done but shows the wear lines of many attempts, which means Starla probably did this herself, a touching, hand-done addition.

Catra suddenly has the fury to fuel her way through the tournament if she did choose to compete. If she did, she might get the opportunity to beat Starla so humiliatingly that Adora wouldn’t even consider accepting.

“You would approve?” Catra questions, too aggressively, but she needs Angella to *stop this*, not encourage it. Angella places the drawing back in the chest.

“I will facilitate whatever Adora desires. It would be a poor repayment for everything she did to not wish her happiness,” Angella says, poised in the way a queen should be, but Catra doesn’t get that title, so she’ll take the brattiness Glimmer displays on a regular basis still.

“She deserves a wife who will provide for her or at least provide her with *excitement*. Starla has been holed up in Peekablue’s court doing nothing but tournaments since the war ended,” Catra snaps. The slow way Angella arches a brow, completely controlled, makes Catra feel like she’s a child again still learning how to behave at the feet of her mothers, her outbursts and comments easily ignored. She knows why, they weren’t appropriate and they needed to move the conversation along in front of important people, but after a childhood in hiding, it made her feel invisible.

“Adora will decide what she wants,” Angella says. Catra growls, sitting forward.

“She’s *your* knight. You decide. And it’s insulting to you. Just throw this out,” Catra demands, waving her hand at the gaudy chest. She hates the way humans do their stupid proposals. It’s ugly. It serves no purpose if it gets rejected, not with those two crests on it that make it impossible to repurpose.

“It takes a bit more than love to insult me. Starla always held affection for Adora. Adora will decide who she holds affection for,” Angella responds. Catra growls, standing to turn away and storm over to the railing so she can wrap her hands around it hard enough to satisfy her need to punch something.

“So I’m just to lose my knight to some court in the North where the only thing of interest that happens is the river flooding with the snowmelt?” Catra demands, glaring at the treetops of the Whispering Woods.

“Has Adora conferred in you that she has fallen for Starla? She has asked to remain at your court thus far,” Angella points out behind her. Catra’s lashing tail freezes mid swing.

“You assign her,” Catra says, words a little slow. She hears some movement at the table behind her, the light tinkling of porcelain as Angella bores with her unbecoming outburst and goes back to her tea.

“Lest you forget, Adora is like a daughter to me, and I let my actual daughter marry for love. I even let her lover have opportunities to gain enough glory to be considered worthy of her by others. Adora requested your court so she could continue fighting and I granted it to her. She has continued to pursue your court since even after Glimmer has lamented her absence growing longer. I doubt she’d want to leave both her court of birth and her court of choice for her ex-fiancé’s proposal, but I must give her the option,” Angella says.

Catra isn’t breathing. That’s- That’s not-

“Adora requested my court?” Catra asks even though she should be better trained politically than to reveal that this is new information to her, or to misconstrue Angella’s words so blatantly if that is what is happening.

Angella takes a drink behind her, and Catra hears it because her ears are *straining* for a response. Angella says nothing until after another soft clink.

“She made a very good point about where her talents would be best suited, but she also said it was where she would be happiest. You deserved her for your efforts, too. It was a perfect match, unlike this one,” Angella says. Catra swallows, eyes wide and trees blurry in her unfocused vision.

Oh.

Catra is going to have a meltdown. She feels a bit faint, even, but at least she’s already gripping the railing.

“I would prefer if you state it in Waste terms to ensure there is no miscommunication,” Catra makes herself say. Angella chuckles to herself.

“I believe that is a conversation best had with Adora, then. It is, after all, her decision, but I know which engagement she chose to break and which she began in the past. I’ll have the proposal delivered to her room so she can go over it in private,” Angella says, and the fact she chose to describe it as an *engagement* has Catra weak in the knees.

How is she supposed to *talk* to Adora about this? What is she supposed to ask? She can't tell if Angella is saying what it sounds like she is to Catra's untrained ear, and if she's not, Catra could easily drive Adora straight into Starla's arms. It would be the most convenient escape.

Maybe that's what they need. Maybe that's the only way to break this clean – for Adora to shoot her down in Bright Moon, where she holds the most power, and for Catra to return to the Waste alone, crying the whole way. If she's so inclined, she could just walk into the sand and disappear after the rejection.

"Angella," Catra begs, voice weak. She needs- she needs something, or she's not going to be able to tear herself from this railing.

"I don't believe she finds the chest necessary. She has had many complaints about the proposal process thus far," is all Angella gives her, and Catra hangs her head. Breathe in. Breathe out.

"She's my knight," is Catra's last protest, as if that will change Angella's mind.

"She is." Catra bites back a whine.

But for how long?

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Adora steps into the suite where she and Catra have been staying to find it in near-darkness compared to the golden afternoon outside. Catra has blocked every window with heavy tapestries thrown over the already-existing curtains. It's not as complete of a barrier as she has in Halfmoon, but it makes it dimmer than Adora's eyes are adjusted to while in Bright Moon and she has to be careful as she makes her way to Catra's bedroom. She never joined them for dinner and Angella said it was because she wasn't feeling up for it after their breakfast. She said she would have bland food sent to their room, but Adora wants to make sure Catra isn't feeling too ill.

She's nowhere to be seen in the main parlor. Adora approaches her door instead, knocking lightly and then opening it.

Catra is lying facedown on her bed, still in all her dress and skirts, seeming to have only discarded her crown upon arrival, leaving her mask lying on the bed beside her.

"Princess?" Adora calls. Catra's tail twitches, but she doesn't otherwise move or respond. Adora cautiously steps inside, glancing around the room to be sure nothing else is amiss. Angella said their breakfast was just a little much for Catra when Adora was worried, but poisoning still occurs to her. It's not a weapon of choice in the Waste since it's viewed as too weak to not be able to defeat your enemy in battle, but they're in Bright Moon, and you never know what agents may be lurking when it's least expected.

“Catra, are you okay?” Adora asks, walking closer and hovering nearby. Catra reluctantly lifts her head and she’s *adorably* rumpled, hair messy and the fur on her cheek sticking up as she squints at Adora. A small smile plays at Adora’s lips.

“How are you feeling?” she asks, stepping closer so she can reach out and smooth Catra’s hair into something assembling shape with her hands. Catra seems a bit flushed, which makes Adora more worried it’s not just a stomachache.

“Fine now,” Catra says, and then drops her head back down to the bed. There’s no way she thinks Adora is going to believe that.

“Angella didn’t say you were so unwell you couldn’t make it to bed. I would have come right away,” Adora says.

“I did make it,” Catra refutes, words muffled by the sheets.

“Fully dressed and face down over the sheets is not the same thing as resting,” Adora chides her, petting over her mane again.

“It seemed too tiring to take it off and then put it back on for dinner,” Catra defends herself in a mumble.

“I can receive dinner for you,” Adora points out. Catra doesn’t move.

“It seemed too tiring to take it off,” Catra amends. Adora chuckles, shaking her head. She runs her hand over Catra’s mane and down to her back, where her corset is laced.

“I can help. You should get in bed and rest until dinner,” Adora promises, resisting the urge to trace her finger over the laces. She wants to so badly that she knows she absolutely can’t. Catra’s tail twitches.

“Will you be staying for it?” Catra asks.

“Yes, of course.” Adora doesn’t know why she even asked. Yes, things are different when they visit Bright Moon, but she’s not going to leave Catra alone in this state.

“You wake early and need to sleep,” Catra points out. That is irrelevant. She’ll wake up to have dinner and then go back to bed if needed. She’ll get a little less sleep. She wants to make sure Catra is okay.

“I also need to eat. I’ll be here for it,” Adora promises.

Catra doesn’t come up with any other protests, falling silent. Adora waits, but she says nothing more. Cautiously, Adora hooks a finger in Catra’s laces and tugs slightly. Catra doesn’t react, so she decides to undo the corset, carefully pulling apart the knot and starting to loosen the lacing so it will be possible to slide it off.

She’s about halfway done when she realizes that Catra is bent facedown over a bed as Adora slowly strips her and suddenly her fingers aren’t cooperating very well. She has to breathe very slowly and purposefully as she finishes and then lightly taps Catra’s shoulder.

“You need to stand up now, Princess. I promise it won’t be long.” It can’t be, because then Catra might detect what she’s doing to Adora.

She’s quite literally doing nothing but lying there – standing, now, as she reluctantly rises and then her back is practically plastered against Adora’s front because she’s standing so close. Bad thoughts, bad thoughts, bad thoughts.

Adora quickly reaches for the edges of Catra’s bodice and pulls it up, Catra lifting her arms to allow it and doing nothing else to help as Adora unfastens her second skirt layer, pushing it off her hips to the ground. The second underdress needs more unlacing, and then Catra shrugs it off her shoulders and flops forward onto the bed in just her shift, worming around to make her way to a comfortable position near the head of the bed as Adora carefully gathers her layers so she can go pack them away without filling them full of wrinkles. It takes her a few minutes – Catra wasn’t *wrong* to say it was a lot of work – but she manages to cool her blood in that time. She turns back to face Catra to find her comfortably curled up – which is to say she’s half-contorted to be on both her back and side, blinking at Adora slowly as the tip of her tail taps against the mattress in a steady rhythm.

“I already feel much better. It’s that pointless corseting,” Catra complains. Adora chuckles, walking back to her bedside.

“I honestly find them comforting like armor. But compression on your midsection while eating rich foods affects you,” Adora acknowledges, resisting the urge to reach for Catra again now she does not physically need her. Catra blinks up at her, slowly.

“Think I can get away with normal clothes until the ball?” she asks. Adora pauses, considering it.

“Maybe for the next two days. Guests are already starting to arrive,” Adora points out. Catra groans, but Adora is right. Catra sighs. She turns her head away, falling silent again. Maybe she isn’t feeling so well.

“Did Angella tell you what she had delivered to your room?” Catra asks. Adora blinks at her.

“Another proposal, right?” she asks, brow furrowing. To her surprise, Catra grumbles to herself.

“An *insulting* proposal,” she corrects. With a heavy sigh, she reaches up and brushes her hair out of her face. “I’m going to take a few minutes to gather myself before I put on my proper clothes. Go read it and then we can continue to whatever evening activities you had planned,” she promises. Adora frowns.

“Are you sure you’re feeling up for it? You don’t need to push yourself,” Adora reinforces. Catra glowers at the wall.

“Breakfast was hours ago, I’m fine now that I can breathe. You don’t need to cancel your plans for me, but I know you’re going to. Take as long as you need with the proposal and I’ll get dressed when you’re ready,” Catra promises. Adora frowns, but she reluctantly nods. There’s one thing Catra won’t take kindly to, and it’s Adora trying to baby her.

“Okay, I won’t be long,” Adora promises her. Catra nods and then lays her head back, closing her eyes as she waits. She’s at least alert, because her ears are completely trained on Adora as she walks from the room.

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Catra waits, straining her ears. She kind of wanted Adora to come rushing into her room with the letter, saying that Catra just had to see this audacity. Instead she hears nothing after Adora goes into her room. Catra suddenly questions her strategy. She should have told Adora what it was so she could frame it as the awful thing it clearly is. She should have gone with her so she could emotionally support Adora through this transgression from her past lover. She should have thrown the hideous thing out the window when Angella had it delivered.

She had a lot of time to think things through this afternoon while she was wallowing, though, and all her next steps rely on her read of Adora’s reaction to this proposal, so she needs her to see it, as much as she hates it. Disposing of it is nothing but a fantasy. It realistically only takes a few minutes, but *eventually* Adora knocks on her door and enters again.

“Ready to go?” Adora asks and her voice is… completely normal. Catra lifts her head to scrutinize her. She *looks* completely normal.

“Are you?” Catra questions. Adora furrows her brow.

“Yes?” Adora sounds a bit confused. Catra huffs, throwing her legs over the mattress and standing.

“Angella told me what was in there,” Catra calls her bluff, because she can’t believe Adora feels *nothing* after reading whatever Starla wrote to convince her she was worthy of her time again.

“Oh.” Adora blinks at her, and then looks away. Catra’s chest feels hot. She turns sharply to walk over to her wardrobe to find new clothes. She’d rather be dressed now, but she’d also rather swoon so she can crawl into bed and never leave. Adora is quiet as Catra starts fumbling through her trunk, not really seeing the clothes before her but needing to find *something*. She doesn’t care about Bright Moon standards, actually, their rituals are terrible. She’s wearing her own clothes today. She’ll go back to proper and formal tomorrow. The kirtle really is fine when you’re not bloated.

“I just… don’t know why she’d do that,” Adora finally says. Catra’s hands still in the middle of their fabric dive. Slowly, she stands and turns to face Adora again.

“Likely either chasing your glory or fantasies that you were the one who got away,” Catra says, eyeing her. Adora tilts her head a little, half shrugging like she can’t quite understand it even though it’s very obvious to Catra.

“She was kind and interesting whenever I met her at tourneys. After we were engaged, we had the opportunity to see each other in person two or three times and were never able to spark anything more,” Adora says like everyone should view it that objectively. People don’t typically view their engagements in such terms, but then again, Catra is used to bonded couples and not an asinine distant arrangement between two distinguished tourney runners.

“Maybe she thought you could grow into someone that would settle for that,” Catra says and she’s pretending to not sound bitter, but she is. Adora’s head tilts slightly in the other direction and Catra suddenly feels as transparent as her nightshift. She’s glad she’s wearing a proper foundation layer for going in public because she doesn’t need to feel more naked during this conversation.

“She was a good woman,” Adora says, neutrally, like she doesn’t know what about Starla could be below her worth. *Everything*. Catra wants to kill her. She still hasn’t ruled out entering the tourney depending how this week goes. She’d rather it was Junipurr, because at least Junipurr is *close* and wouldn’t lure Adora away.

“You deserve better. A better fighter, a better family, a better home and dowry. Even the throne in her small court doesn’t compare to your position here,” Catra argues. Peekablue’s court is just too small to deserve Adora’s presence. If Catra lost her to a noble in Bright Moon, it would kill her, but she would understand it.

She would also still get to visit Adora regularly.

“I hardly think that’s true,” Adora says, sounding bemused. Catra is feeling too violent to keep her expression in check. She scoffs and turns back to her trunk.

“You’re not indulging this, are you?” Catra clarifies, trying to keep her voice neutral enough that the sneer comes off as offense on Adora’s behalf rather than outright disgust.

“No, but I don’t know how I’m going to let her down in person. I’ve never known the person I was rejecting before. When we broke the engagement, she was deployed. It was hard to say it to her brother, but he at least understood and I knew would pass on the message and my letter delicately. I’m not a very… delicate person,” Adora admits and Catra can suddenly breathe again. She has her own ideas how Adora could do it, but she can’t share them now.

“Have Angella take the chest, at least. She can give it back to her even if you tell her in person first so it will be clear it’s not something you’re entertaining,” Catra says. She has been thinking about this a *lot* and she doesn’t want Starla to cling to the hope of Adora keeping the chest. It’s common to send the rejection back in whatever casing the proposal came in, but having Angella specifically deliver it will make it clear there is no chance of this being renegotiated. Angella’s word on the matter is final. Catra manages to find one of two ceremonial robes she packed and pulls it out. Now she just needs the matching pants and then she can be *comfortable*. Adora sighs.

“I’ll probably have her deliver it. It depends who she arrives with, too. I have a few days to think on it,” Adora agrees. Good. Good.

Catra is going to give her something else to think about in that time. If Adora really can't stand it, well, then she'll do it before Starla arrives so Adora can accept if she's really inclined to flee.

The problem is Catra doesn't know when Starla is actually arriving for the gala, and worse, she needs Angella's help, if not her *permission*, to get this done. Once she asks, there's no backing out.

She probably needs that if she's ever going to do it.

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The journey to Bright Moon is always fun because Adora gets to ride once they reach the edge of the Whispering Woods, a usually impractical mode of transport in the Waste, but it's not the same thing as tournament riding, so Adora is spending all day at the tourney grounds, practicing first just riding, and then riding with her lance, and then putting on her armor for a few rounds before she puts it all together. At the start of the day she's alone, Glimmer having matters to attend to and Bow with Angel at his lessons, not to mention Catra being *asleep*, but by the time Adora and her horse are thoroughly exhausted and ready for a late afternoon lunch, the couple and their young son are in the stands. Angel's little claps call Adora over to the stands when she finally unmounts, pulling off her helmet and panting a little from the heat even if it's nothing compared to the Waste.

"Woo! Go, Adora!" Angel cheers even though she's already done and Adora grins as she walks up to the bottom of the stands. These are the lower ones intended for the main bulk of the tourney guests. Angella's taller tourney box with a view of the entire run is already built, but less convenient for quick observation. Adora waves her hands at Angel and watches the little boy clap with delight, twin purple buns bobbing, but then she looks up to his parents and frowns.

"Have you seen Catra?" she asks. She should be up by now. Adora thought she was coming to watch. Normally she follows Adora around while they're in Bright Moon even if she should never be in danger here because an attack in Angella's castle would result in the full military might of the continent coming down on the culprit.

"I think Mom said she had something booked for her today," Glimmer says, waving her hand. Oh. Catra didn't mention anything, so she probably only found out today, which explains her not showing up.

"Do you think she'll be able to join us for dinner?" Adora asks, looking back at her horse. Maybe she can do a little more practice this evening when Catra is free again.

"You'll have to ask Mom. It's boiling, are you ready to go inside?" Glimmer asks. Adora glances down at her helmet.

“Yeah, just let me change first,” she agrees reluctantly. She loves Bright Moon, but she often misses Catra while here.

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Catra was getting nervous that the fruits of her secret errand wouldn’t arrive in time, the tourney only two days away and the first practices *tomorrow*, but the package arrives to their suite at the worst time – while they’re both in it getting ready for the day. Catra stares at it, horrified, as the deliveryman holds it out to her.

“Delivery for Princess Catra from the Moonstone Tailors,” he says, bowing. Catra stares down at the ornate box, finding her hands won’t lift. The deliveryman remains bowed, seeing unsure, hands starting to waver a little as he holds the box above his head.

“Thank you,” Adora steps in for her, appearing at Catra’s side and moving to take the box for her. Probably for the best, because Catra hears some of the wind leave Adora as she takes the heavy box from him. The man immediately straightens, shooting her a grateful smile.

“Good day, Princess,” he bids them both. Catra nods jerkily to him and then closes the door as Adora turns away to deposit the box on their dining table. Catra remains staring at the back of the door as she listens to the thud of the box being set down.

“What, does this have your dress for the gala in it?” Adora jokes behind her, but she sounds a little uncertain, probably because Catra *never* freezes up. Catra swallows, closing her eyes to gather herself.

“No, I believe Glimmer is preparing an abomination for me and not giving me enough forewarning to say no,” Catra says, feeling no less prepared when she opens her eyes. Slowly, she turns to find Adora standing over the box with a furrow in her brow. It was a silly idea anyway, it’s far too small for whatever Glimmer is going to do to her. It’s her gala and she said Catra didn’t have anything that would fit the theming, so she was taking matters into her own hands. Catra knows it’s a sign of her friendship that she’s helping her navigate Bright Moon fashion standards, but she also hates Bright Moon fashion standards.

Adora glances back down at the box. She has one hand on the front of the lid already like she wants to open it. Catra wraps her arms around herself and then clears her throat to cover up the moment of weakness.

“It’s your tabard for the tourney. Angella has your old one if you prefer it, but I had it made using some of the scales you recovered on your hunting trip so you can showcase your recent accomplishments,” Catra states, voice formal like she’s presenting it in front of an audience like she initially planned. She wasn’t going to use them in a tabard and instead put them on some actual armor, but Adora said she didn’t want lighter formal armor, and Catra wanted to leave her own touch on the tabard. Adora’s mouth forms a small *o* and then she turns back to the chest, opening it.

Adora freezes. Catra holds her breath. Time stops.

It doesn't restart. They're both just standing there, frozen. Even when Adora's hands do move, it seems like they're numb, because she fumbles a little with the tabard when she reaches in and holds it up, watching it unfurl as the full crest becomes visible, the scales lightly tinkling together as they're disturbed. Adora's eyes trace over the full length of the tabard slowly, taking in the crest in the center, the decorative scales along the sides and sewn in to highlight key parts of the crest. They couldn't use most of the scales that Catra brought because few of them were in the right colors.

There aren't a lot of red lizardfolk. Lashor's pink scales were the closest they could get, and then they bleached others for decorative details that don't clash. Adora stares at the crest in the middle that bares no moon or stars, taking it in with wide eyes. Catra's claws are out and digging into her dress sleeves as Adora's eyes dart over the crest before, finally, *slowly*, they turn to land on Catra.

"Catra- Is this- I can't-" Adora starts to say and Catra's heart might leave her chest and take up residence in the Northern Reach.

"You can if you're part of my court. Permanently," Catra says. No matter how long Angella assigns Adora to Catra's court, she is still technically Angella's knight and not Catra's. They can't change that without Adora giving up her Knight-Princess title.

There are ways she can join Catra's court while still being the knight of another, though. Adora's tongue darts out to wet her lips and then her eyes flicker to the crest for a moment before landing on Catra again. Catra might be able to hear her heartbeat. It's hard beneath the hammering of her own.

"Catra, what is this?" Adora asks, and her voice is weak.

Catra almost considers calling it a stupid gift – a fantasy and nothing more. Nothing at all.

She takes a deep breath, eyes landing on the box it arrived in.

"Well, it is a chest. Not quite as fancy as Starla's, but I was on a time crunch," Catra manages, joke shaky. The tabard falls a few inches as Adora suddenly lowers her arms as if the tabard is getting in the way of staring at Catra. After a second of gaping, she turns her gaze back to the chest. Catra sees her eyes widen when she sees what's sitting at the bottom of it.

She considered writing her a stupid letter like Starla did, but that's a Bright Moon tradition, and Adora *did* tell her she prefers the Waste's way of courting, so she asked the tailor to find silk ropes. They said they would be white, which isn't the meaning Catra really wants for the ropes, but she's working with what she has. Traditionally both partners pick them out to create their knotwork piece and tie their lives together forever, so when they get back to the Waste – if Adora comes with her at all – they can both pick out a proper set. This is just her intent, to make things completely clear.

Adora is just staring again. Catra thinks she might actually faint. She feels like it. She shouldn't have done it like this, she shouldn't have just *proposed*, but she didn't know what else to do. She never felt right making further romantic overtures with Adora than she already has. It's not like they need a courting period. At this point, Adora either knows she wants Catra like that or she doesn't. The tourney is about to happen and Catra can't stand Adora competing under the wrong banner, or getting *more* proposals. She's sure Starla isn't the only one who prepared one for the gala, just the only one who sent it ahead of them. The older Adora gets, the more people will expect the war trophy married off.

Catra doesn't want her because of that. She wants her because she loves her.

Adora lowers the tabard to rest of the way to the table, like she needs to be able to brace herself.

"Catra, why are you proposing?" Adora whispers, eyes still locked on the ropes. Catra's arms tighten around her stomach. She thinks she's going to be sick. She screws her eyes shut.

"Because I'm an idiot, apparently. I'm sorry. I'll- dispose of it," she whispers, wishing she didn't sound so wrecked, but Adora is lucky that she isn't sobbing right now. She hears the crinkle of the scales as Adora seemingly jerks, but if Catra opens her eyes she *is* going to cry, so Adora can look at her with whatever disgust she wants for now. So many moments must feel violating in retrospect.

They always were. Catra forces herself to swallow three times to keep a sob from slipping out or something working up from her stomach, and she flinches – *flinches!* She's an embarrassment to them both – when she hears Adora's footsteps approaching.

"Catra, I- Why? Actually why?" Adora asks, her hand reaching out to gently cover Catra's own where it's clutching her arm. Catra has to take two slow breaths in a row to be able to reply in words.

"Because I want you to be mine, Adora. I always have. I thought maybe you did too," Catra whispers. It's all she can say.

She's a bad queen. So is Angella. She never should have encouraged this, covered for her, *rushed the tailor* to ensure Catra's order was prioritized first. She should have let her rot in her loneliness forever. What can she even do to make Adora comfortable with her again?

Adora's free hand reaches up, cupping Catra's cheek and encouraging her to lift her head. Catra's eyes blink open in surprise and find the only thing on Adora's face to be nerves.

"So, do you mean that as your knight, or as your actual lover?" Adora questions and Catra gapes at her. Adora's cheeks flush. "You're not- Usually you're direct," she justifies, chewing on her lip. Yes, but usually Catra isn't scared *shitless* and she doesn't remember an opponent in battle ever making her feel this way.

"Adora, I love you," Catra whispers, voice a bit desolate. She needs Adora to just understand so she can end this. Adora's lips part and she stares at Catra in shock like she didn't just

*propose* to her. “I’d prefer if you gut me at this point,” Catra jokes, pathetically, but it’s honestly how she’s feeling. Just end it.

Adora’s hand shifts from her cheek to hook under her ear, fingers curling around the back of her head so she can pull a shocked Catra forward into a kiss.

If Catra wasn’t breathing before, she certainly isn’t now. She felt *so cold* watching Adora stare into the chest, but Adora’s lips are hot against her own, as is her arm wrapping around Catra’s waist as she pulls her in against her and almost pulls Catra off her feet.

This is that experience Adora got with Starla, but *Catra* gets to experience it now as a purr flows out of her and she clumsily tries to kiss back, one arm lifting to hook around the back of Adora’s neck. Adora’s lips are hungry against hers and suddenly, Catra can feel her blood stirring in her veins. The number of times she has fantasized about a moment like this is unreasonable, and when Adora slows the kiss, she whimpers slightly, not ready for it to end.

She *hears* Adora smirk.

“So you *were* whispering my name at night,” Adora purrs to her and suddenly Catra’s face is on fire, her tail lashing behind her.

“You- You heard-” Adora chuckles, and then kisses Catra again, this time open-mouthed, and Glimmer can rot at breakfast because Catra is never leaving this room.

“I wasn’t sure,” Adora admits, lips brushing against Catra’s before she kisses her again. Catra is a flustered mess. She always knew there was a *chance*, that’s why she always tried to bite down Adora’s name as she imagined how her fingers would feel inside her, but Adora never gave her any indication the next day that she had heard anything, not even acting oddly.

“Were you picturing my hand instead?” Adora asks, voice low enough to make Catra’s knees weak. For a moment her mouth is too dry to speak.

“Accept my proposal before you say such things to me, because I’m not leaving your mouth free *after*,” Catra orders. Adora sucks in a sharp breath. She presses one last quick kiss against Catra’s lips before pulling back it make eye contact with Catra.

“I’ve wanted you since you walked into the war council for the first time. I’ll gladly be your princess,” Adora promises her.

Catra takes a minute before following through on her threat because she’s too busy gaping at Adora. When she does, though, she throws her entire body at Adora because she’s planning for them to end up far, far from the front door, and she grabs her head to drag her into a blazing kiss. Adora might laugh into the kiss, but she’s a little too busy doing what she should be doing – kissing Catra back – to fully form it.

Given how this conversation has gone, she probably should have told Adora she was interested in her before the proposal, but the end result is Adora bending down and quite literally lifting Catra off her feet to carry her back to her bedroom, so the temporary emotional-turmoil-based illness is all worth it.

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The tourney grounds are already filled the day before the event. Everyone is rooting for their own knight, but betting on them? Most of the time the most likely winner won't be from your home and now is the time for onlookers to judge the best placement for their bets. The knights themselves are happy for the time to prepare and learn the grounds, even if Adora has a head start on that.

She has barely ridden in the last few years, she thinks this is fair, btu she has to share the green now.

She's in a tent in the back of the tourney grounds, testing out her gloves because she didn't like how inconsistent her grip on the reins felt. She still has good sync with Swift Wind, but she can't tell if the problem is her gloves or the reins. She hasn't done many runs wearing her ceremonial armor along with Swift Wind's full regalia, but she has to wear this armor, so she's hoping the issue is the reigns. Those are easier to change out, they don't have the same meaning or requirements as her armor.

"Princess Adora?" a voice calls from the entrance and Adora feels a small flutter to her heart, because yes, she has been called that many times, but this is the first time it's really *true*.

Okay, not yet, but she and Catra are already in talks to plan their wedding, because both courts need to be involved and it's easier to do initial planning together while they're already here. Also then Adora gets to talk about marrying Catra constantly.

Adora turns towards the front of the tent to find her tent's guard – there mostly for show but also to make sure no one sabotages her gear while unattended – holding the door aside just enough for her to see another person standing over his shoulder, waiting to get the all-clear to let them in.

"Yes?"

"Ser Star is here to see you," he says.

Oh.

She… was kind of planning to avoid her. She only got in last night, it seemed plausible. Adora just turning her away without speaking to her wouldn't be better than anything she could say, though. She takes a deep breath and nods, lowering her gauntlet. The guard steps aside and Starla takes his place.

She only gets one step inside the tent when she freezes, eyes adjusted to the shade enough to see what Adora is wearing. Adora gives her a small, apologetic smile.

"The formal announcement will be at the gala, but I'm wearing my betrothed's colors for the tourney. I'm sorry I didn't have time to find you and return your proposal first," Adora says,

because it will be obvious to everyone what *could* have happened when they see her competing. There will be rumors and buzz up until the gala where Glimmer has been planning the formal announcement with glee.

She has many complaints about how this guarantees Adora is going to spend her foreseeable future in the Waste, but she also knows how long Adora has loved Catra and is delighted for her. She's also just delighted to have a wedding to plan, and this one will be *complicated* considering there is no royal wedding between Bright Moon and the magicats recorded in history and thus they are creating the standards for themselves.

"You're already engaged?" Starla asks in a small voice, eyes finally raising from Adora's tabard to meet her eyes. Adora's smile is tight.

"Yes, to Princess Catra. I'm quite fond of her after serving in her court for years," Adora says. She hopes this will make the rejection easier. She decided with Catra and Angella that they would say Catra had decided to propose to her a while ago and used the tabard upon their arrival to do it formally, before they even found out about the proposal from Starla. Adora never could have accepted it she even wanted to.

The way Starla's face falls makes Adora think Starla's intentions with the proposal were more innocent than Catra suspected, but even now, Adora can't imagine why she did it.

"I'm sorry, Starla, but I'm happy with her and the courts didn't find a match between us to be appropriate regardless," Adora says, which is technically true considering Catra was going to oppose it to her dying day and Angella did admit it was a poor match even if she claims she wouldn't have gotten in the way.

Adora suspects she would have stepped in if Adora genuinely had any intention of considering it, but she will always be grateful for the way Angella has cared for her since the moment she was orphaned in her guard.

"I- It's quite alright. I understand. Congratulations, it's a truly incredible match for you," Starla says, ducking her head a little, and Adora feels bad. Starla is right – it's the kind of match most can only dream of, and Adora *has* been dreaming of it.

"We may have a joust at the wedding. I won't be competing for once," Adora jokes, an olive branch that makes Starla let out a soft *ha* and shake her head.

"I think I will save myself the embarrassment when I know I'm already defeated, but we'll see what we manage tomorrow," Starla offers. Adora's lips twitch.

"I'll be competing under my wife's banner for the first time. I have no intention of disappointing her," Adora warns. Starla's laugh is a little more polite than amused, but she doesn't look deeply depressed at the news.

"I'd expect nothing less. I look forward to watching it no matter what happens," she agrees. Adora doesn't know if she's going to win considering she has only had a week to practice, but she knows that at the end it will be impossible for anyone to say she didn't put on a good show.

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Catra is actually fine sitting up in Angella's box now Adora is jousting in her colors, Catra's dress perfectly matched to *their* crest.

Rumors are running rampant throughout the guests and tourney grounds. Adora said a couple people have asked her already and she just said she is competing under her court and walked away. A formal announcement needs to be made and the gala is the perfect time for it rather than doing it a dozen times with every curious onlooker. It's hardly a secret with Adora dressed like this.

Admittedly, to Catra's eye at least, the grays and blacks of her crest don't compliment Adora's white and gold armor very well, but Adora seemed to think it worked Catra has no way of imagining red, so she has to just take her word for it. Frankly, she doesn't care about the color at all when her mark is emblazoned on Adora's chest, instantly purring whenever Adora appears on the field. She knows she does this, because Glimmer always cheers for Adora, glances at Catra, and then snickers. Catra is usually focusing all her attention on Adora and not concerning herself with what her own body is doing, because it's clearly not as important as sitting forward, ears pricked, and watching Adora's helmet plume trail behind her as Swift Wind charges down the grass.

Catra will admit a joust does not hold the same interest to her as watching Adora decimate on the training yard, but Adora wouldn't be wearing Catra's tabard for that, so the joust has a unique thrill, especially knowing Adora's prospective fiancé already got eliminated from the tourney and this is all Catra's – now, tonight when she's going to need Adora to *ravage* her after this cocky display, and forever, from dancing at the gala to the joy of arriving back home engaged. She has fantasized about Adora being *hers* – her knight, her lover, her *wife* – many times and never expected to get any of them.

She's still possessive and she's never going to be anything less – she's the only child of *queens,* after all, she wasn't born to share – but she has nothing to be jealous of now because it's all hers. Watching Adora display that at a tourney and gala featuring nobility from all corners of the world will mark her as Catra's forever. Some of these people will never make the journey to Bright Moon again, or won't for a few years. Their final impression will be the buzz of the mysterious court change and then the excitement of the engagement announcement. Adora will be hers forever in their memories.

And in practice. Adora better keep her damn helmet on as long as they're in public so Catra can hold herself back from kissing her until they're in private tonight.

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Adora almost never wears a dress. She can't wear anything less than a gown or her ceremonial armor for the gala, though, and it's no place for armor. Her dress was arranged before she came, so it's in Angella's colors, but officially she's not Catra's yet, so the two of them bearing the markings of their – current – respective courts makes sense as a visual representation of their oncoming union.

Adora still briefly considers asking Glimmer if she can change it after Catra's reaction to her showing in the tourney wearing her tabard, even if she didn't come in first place. Silver is a good result for someone so far from the world of jousting at this point. She was going into it at a strong disadvantage with the armor she was required to wear as the Knight-Princess. It's meant to display status, not be flexible, and her winning relies on her not getting knocked to ground where it is hard to recover. She managed it until the very end and she's not upset at the result. She might be if Catra hadn't acted like she was a goddess walking the earth afterwards, but it's kind of hard to focus on that part even if she's missing the comfort of her armor right now.

Glimmer got them gowns that aren't too uncomfortable, but Adora hates the wide skirts, because it means they can't press nearly as close together as she wants to, but that's probably the best for decorum's sake. This ball is very important. Glimmer's opening speech from the balcony is long because it has to be, this event upgraded post-war from a small party to when many elite from all corners of the world flock together. Usually multiple marriages are arranged here every year, along with other political negotiations. Glimmer is mostly using her speech as an opportunity to reinforce the benefits of international cooperation, but Adora is only half-listening with how long it drags on.

Glimmer probably expected that, because when she finishes the speech, she claps her hands together.

"I'm thrilled for the dancing to begin, but I must dedicate this first song to two people very important to me," Glimmer says, which is Adora's cue to look to her left and hold out her hand to Catra, a smile dancing on her lips just looking at her. Catra takes it, making eye contact to smile shyly for some reason and letting Adora lead her from the edge of the waiting audience to the center of the empty dance floor, kept care by the courteous guests, as Glimmer continues.

"Knight-Princess Adora Grayskull is a close personal confidant of mine and a jewel of the Bright Moon court. Many of you will be familiar with how she led our army during the war. All of us own our peace in part to Adora," Glimmer introduces as they reach the center of the room, Adora now blushing.

"Princess Catra of Halfmoon also made vital contributions to the war, uniting a new army to bolster our ranks to the much-needed numbers. Her mind for strategy saw her and Adora making the battle plans that let us be able to have a party like this without fear of what waits at our shores," Glimmer continues as Adora and Catra turn to face each other on the center of the floor. Adora tightens her hand in Catra's and then places her other hand on Catra's waist. Catra steps into position as she places her free hand on Adora's other shoulder.

"They have contributed more than I can name and still leave us time to dance, and I am thrilled to announce that Princess Adora and Princess Catra are now betrothed to be married.

This first song is dedicated to them until they are able to dance together at their wedding," Glimmer says, and just the words make Adora grin as they begin to move, sweeping to the side in a practiced waltz. Adora is very used to dancing at parties like this from a young age, but Catra only learned at the end of the war, Halfmoon dances very different in style and protocol. Still, she's a natural, and just a little practice in the week since they've arrived has been enough to get her back in time. Throughout the crowd around them, applause rises, polite compared to what a Halfmoon reaction would be, but this is what is considered appropriate for an event like this. Adora doesn't really care about anyone's reaction to their engagement because it's for them, not peace and unity, no matter how Glimmer dresses it up to justify it to the masses.

"Please, dance in their honor!" Glimmer declares, and the crowd holds back for a moment to respect them before sweeping forward to the floor. Adora is sure fewer people would swarm the floor if not for Glimmer's words, but instead they're quickly surrounded. Even still, a wide circle is left for them. Adora finds herself grinning as she spins Catra.

The song is long, and they must dance for the whole thing. Then they dance for the second, and the third, and only on the fourth do Catra's eyes drift out to the edge of the floor. Adora leads her from the crowd and scrutiny, finding Glimmer's table where they both can take a rest to talk to one of their closest friends. Catra will always be a bit foreign in this court, the way the Waste operates different on every level from dress, to dancing, to daylight hours, but now she is officially a part of it through Adora, Adora predicts their time in the Waste will get a bit easier.

Glimmer's speech demonstrates why it was always a terrible idea to challenge either of them, but she thinks even the most reckless tribes will know better than to mess with Catra, Adora, and the Bright Moon court directly through them. Things might get a bit boring, to be honest, but maybe that's the decades of fighting talking and she just doesn't understand peace yet. If they have fewer hunting parties to go on, well, they'll just have more time together in the palace. They have many years of longing glances to catch up on, and she doesn't think they're ever going to stop coming up with new ways to want each other that they need to fulfill.

Their lives have been filled with challenges to conquer. She might miss the victories, but if Catra is her spoil of war, she'll be happy to have won her.

Chapter End Notes

Final notes:
-This AU was inspired by many Tumblr posts, most of which I didn't share here until now due to being spoilers, but all of them are in the Her Liege tag on my Tumblr (at the beginning of it).
-I also thought back to this (extremely NSFW) art I saw on Twitter years ago when writing it.
-Angella very carefully did not say Catra was actually sick from the food because she

highly suspected she was emotionally unwell and not physically after their conversation lol Adora just made assumptions (that Angella led her towards).
-The main mode of transport in the Waste (other than walking) is sleds with large fans on them that are assisted by the wind. These are then attached to beasts of burden (to steer and in case the wind dies) and make it much easier to move the extra weight through the sand without the mule sinking into it.
-I think after a couple years together they adopt an orphan in the court like Adora once was and that becomes their heir. It wouldn't be an acceptable lineage in some of the other courts, but the Waste doesn't play by those restrictive rules.

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